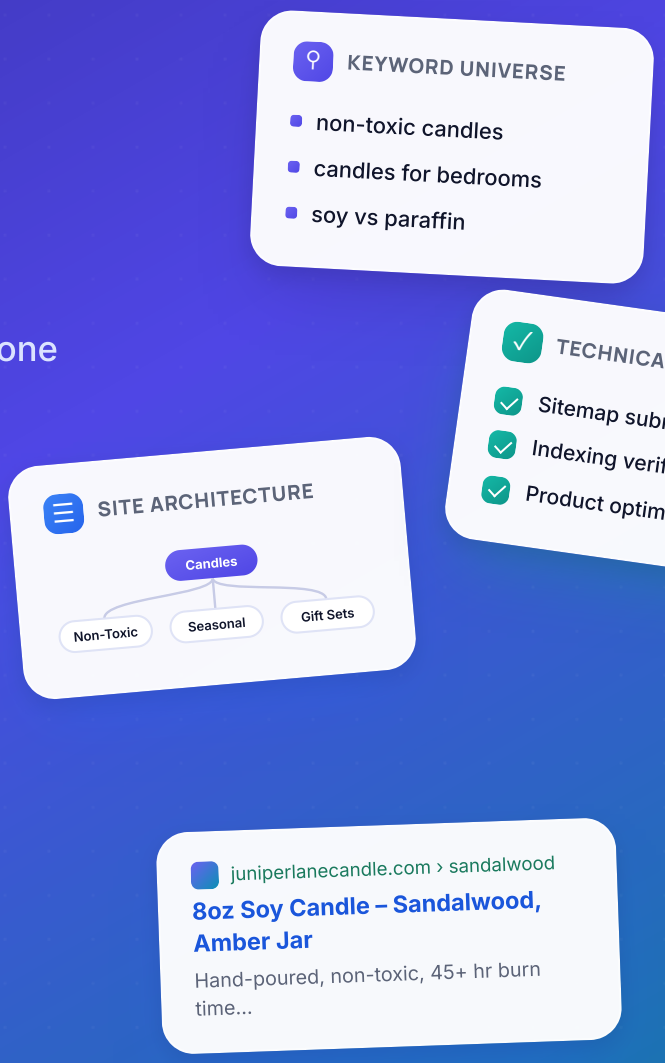
SCROLLY WORKBOOK SERIES

SHOPIFY SEO WORKBOOK

Build your store's organic growth system — one worksheet at a time.



ScrollySEO

27	29	1
WORKSHEETS	SECTIONS	COMPLETE SEO PLAN

Welcome

You didn't start a Shopify store because you wanted to become an SEO expert. You started it because you make or sell something you believe in, and you want people to actually find it.

This workbook won't turn you into an SEO expert either — and it doesn't need to. What it will do is walk you through the same core decisions a paid search strategist would walk you through, in plain English, with a place to write down your own answers as you go.

By the end, you won't have *read about* an SEO strategy. You'll have *built one* — for your store, with your products, using your own keywords, structured around your own collections. That finished, personalized plan is the actual product here. The teaching is just how we get you there.

A few things before you start:

- **This is a workbook, not a book.** You'll get the most value if you have your Shopify admin open in one tab and this workbook open next to it, filling things in as you go rather than reading it cover to cover first.
- **We'll never ask you to guess at numbers you don't have.** Every worksheet either uses your own store data, walks you to a free tool to look something up, or clearly labels a number as an example, not a fact about your business.
- **Paid ads aren't the enemy here, and neither is SEO.** They solve different problems. Section 2 will help you think clearly about which one deserves your next dollar or hour — that decision is personal to your business, and we'll give you a framework, not a verdict.
- **"Good enough" beats "perfect."** You will not finish this workbook with flawless SEO. You'll finish it with a real, prioritized, working system — which is what actually moves the needle, and what most stores never get around to building at all.

Let's get your store found.

What You'll Need

Have these open or nearby before you start:

- [ ] Access to your Shopify admin (Store owner or Staff account with theme/settings permissions)
- [ ] A list of your top 5–10 products or product types
- [ ] A spreadsheet, notebook, or doc to hold your growing keyword and content lists (this workbook has fillable tables, but you'll outgrow the page — that's a good sign)
- [ ] A Google account (needed for Google Search Console, Keyword Planner, and Google Trends — all free)
- [ ] About 3–5 focused hours to get through Parts 1–3 the first time; the rest of the workbook is designed to be worked through over your first 90 days, not in one sitting

You do **not** need: a marketing degree, a paid SEO tool subscription, a developer, or prior SEO experience.

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PART 0

YOUR STARTING POINT

00

✦ YOUR SYSTEM SO FAR

YOU ARE HERE

Part 0 — Your Starting Point

Part 1 · Your Organic Traffic Foundation

Part 2 · Find What People Are Searching For

+ 8 more

Your 3-Question Store Health Check

Before you spend a single hour on keyword research or collection strategy, answer these three questions. They take about five minutes combined, and they catch the single most common reason a Shopify store gets zero organic traffic: **Google was never able to see it in the first place.**

This isn't the full technical SEO lesson — that's coming in Part 6. This is a red-flag check. If you fail one of these, fix it today, then come back and keep going.

Question 1: Is your storefront actually public?

What this means: Shopify lets you password-protect your store — useful before launch, invisible to Google forever if you forget to turn it off. A password-protected store cannot be crawled, indexed, or found in search, no matter how good the rest of your SEO is.

How to check it right now: Go to **Settings** → **Preferences** in your Shopify admin. Look for "Password protection."

- ✅ **Pass:** The box is unchecked, or you can browse to your store's live URL in a private/incognito window without being asked for a password.
- 🚩 **Fail:** The box is checked, or your storefront prompts for a password.

If you fail: Uncheck it (once you're actually ready for customers and search engines to see the store). This one setting has silently kept more new Shopify stores invisible to Google than any actual SEO mistake. Full explanation of crawling and indexing is in **Section 16**.

Question 2: Have you ever connected Google Search Console to your store?

What this means: Google Search Console (GSC) is a free tool from Google that shows you whether Google actually knows your pages exist, whether it's running into errors trying to read them, and how you're performing in search results. Without it, you're guessing.

How to check it right now: Go to search.google.com/search-console and see if your store's domain is already listed as a verified property.

- ✅ **Pass:** Your domain is there, verified, with a sitemap submitted.
- 🚩 **Fail:** Nothing's there, or you're not sure if it was ever set up.

If you fail: That's completely normal for a new or small store — you're not behind, you just haven't done it yet. Full step-by-step setup, including exactly how to verify a Shopify domain, is in **Section 17**. It takes about 15 minutes.

Question 3: When you search Google for your own store name, does your store show up?

What this means: This is the fastest possible manual indexing check — no tools, no login, just Google.

How to check it right now: Open a new private/incognito browser window (so your own search history doesn't skew the results) and search: `[your store name]`. Then try `site:youdomain.com` (replace with your actual domain, no spaces).

- ✅ **Pass:** Your store's homepage appears, and the `site:` search shows a handful of your pages.
- 🚩 **Fail:** Nothing from your store shows up at all, even for your own brand name.

If you fail: Combined with a "fail" on Question 1, this almost always means password protection or a very new/unindexed store (see Question 1's fix). If Question 1 passed and this still fails, your store may simply be too new for Google to have crawled it yet, or there's a technical block worth investigating in **Section 16**.

What your results mean:

YOUR RESULTS	WHAT TO DO
All 3 passed	You're in good shape technically. Proceed to Part 1 — your job now is strategy, not plumbing.
Failed Question 1 only	Fix it today, then proceed to Part 1. Indexing will catch up over the next 1–4 weeks as Google recrawls.
Failed Question 2	No urgent fix needed, but set aside 15 minutes for Section 17 this week — you'll want that data by the time you finish Part 2.
Failed Question 3, or failed multiple	Read Section 16 before investing heavily in the content and page-optimization work in Parts 3–5. Building a beautiful house on a foundation Google can't see wastes your time.

DO THIS NOW

Answer all three questions before turning the page. If you failed Question 1, fix it before you do anything else in this workbook.

PART 1

01

YOUR ORGANIC TRAFFIC FOUNDATION

✦ YOUR SYSTEM SO FAR

Part 0 · Your Starting Point

YOU ARE HERE

Part 1 — Your Organic Traffic Foundation

Part 2 · Find What People Are Searching For

Part 3 · Turn Keywords Into a Shopify Store

+ 7 more

SECTION 1

Why Organic Discovery Still Matters

LEARN

"SEO" used to mean one thing: rank on Google. That's no longer the whole picture — not because Google stopped mattering, but because *where people search* has spread out.

Here's the honest state of discovery in 2026:

- **Google** remains a major high-intent discovery channel for ecommerce — "buy soy candles," "non toxic candles near me" are exactly the ready-to-buy searches that happen there. It's still where most of this workbook focuses.
- **Google's Shopping tab** shows free product listings (not just paid ads) to stores that meet some basic requirements — a real, no-bid channel worth setting up once your product data is clean, covered in the Toolkit (Section 27).
- **YouTube** is a search engine in its own right — "how to," "review," and "vs" searches happen there constantly, and it's owned by Google, which means video content can also surface in regular Google search results.
- **TikTok, Instagram, and Pinterest** are where a meaningful and growing share of younger shoppers *start* their product research — not instead of search entirely, but as a genuine first stop, especially for visual, lifestyle, or gift purchases. Part 7 covers what "SEO" means on these platforms, because it isn't the same game as Google.
- **AI assistants** like ChatGPT are an emerging discovery surface — people are starting to ask them directly for product recommendations. Part 8 covers this honestly, including what we do and don't yet know about how to influence it.

The reason this matters for a small Shopify store specifically: **you don't have to pick one.** Unlike paid advertising, where every new channel means a new budget line, most of what makes you discoverable in one of these places (clear product information, real customer language, genuine expertise, useful content) makes you *more* discoverable in the others too. That's the compounding advantage of organic work — it's not really "SEO" in five different places. It's one asset (a genuinely well-explained, well-organized store) that shows up in more places over time.

SEE

Juniper Lane Candle Co. sells hand-poured soy candles. A customer might reach them through:

- Google: searching "non toxic candles for sensitive skin"
- Google Shopping tab: browsing candles under $30 with free shipping
- Pinterest: saving a "cozy fall home" board that includes a Juniper Lane product photo

- TikTok: watching a “candles that don’t give me a headache” video that mentions the brand

- ChatGPT: asking “what’s a good housewarming gift under $40” and getting Juniper Lane mentioned because it’s well-reviewed and clearly described online

Same store. Five different doors in.

DO

✎ Worksheet — Where Can Customers Discover Me?

For each channel below, rate how likely your *actual* customers are to search for products like yours there (High / Some / Unlikely), based on who you sell to — not on where you personally spend time.

CHANNEL	LIKELIHOOD MY CUSTOMERS SEARCH HERE	WHY (ONE LINE)	AM I CURRENTLY DOING ANYTHING HERE?
Google Search			
Google Shopping (free listings)			
YouTube			
TikTok			
Instagram			
Pinterest			
AI assistants (ChatGPT, etc.)			
Other (Reddit, forums, marketplaces)			

Circle your top 2 “High” channels. Everything through Part 6 of this workbook builds your Google foundation, which supports every other channel. Parts 7 and 8 come back to your other high-likelihood channels specifically — and if “Google Shopping (free listings)” rated High for you, Section 9 walks through setting that up once you’ve optimized your first product.

CHECK YOUR WORK

You should have at least one “High” and it should make intuitive sense for your product — a visually giftable product (like candles, jewelry, or home goods) usually rates high on Pinterest/Instagram; a problem-solving purchase (like supplements or tools) usually rates high on Google and YouTube. If everything on your list is “Unlikely,” that’s a sign to revisit who you think your customer actually is before continuing.



SECTION 2

SEO vs. Paid Traffic

LEARN

These solve two different problems, and the confusion between them is where a lot of new store owners waste money or lose patience.

Paid traffic (Meta ads, TikTok ads, Google Ads) buys you a customer *right now*, for as long as you keep paying. The moment you stop the campaign, that traffic stops. Its main value: it's fast, testable, and scalable once you know your numbers — you can turn it up as soon as it's profitable.

Organic search traffic (SEO) doesn't have a per-click cost, but it isn't free — it costs research time, content creation, and store-structure work up front, and it takes weeks to months to build momentum (more on realistic timelines in Section 23). Its main value: a well-built product page or article keeps earning you visits long after you stopped actively working on it. That's what "compounding" means here — the asset keeps paying you back.

Neither one is the "right" answer for every store. A few honest tradeoffs:

	PAID TRAFFIC	ORGANIC SEARCH
Speed to first customer	Fast (days)	Slow (weeks–months)
Cost structure	Ongoing, per click/impression	Upfront time/content investment, then low marginal cost
Requires testing before it's efficient	Yes — creatives, audiences, offers	Less "testing," more "building"
Stops working if you stop paying/working	Immediately	Gradually — content and structure keep working for a while
Best for	Validating offers, launching new products fast, driving a specific promotion	Long-term brand discoverability, buyers who research before buying

A new ecommerce store often needs real testing spend on paid before it becomes predictable — trying different creatives, audiences, offers, landing pages, and products, and giving each test enough budget and time to produce a meaningful read. There isn't one universal dollar figure for how much that testing costs — it depends heavily on your price point, margin, and platform, and anyone who quotes you one exact number is guessing. What *is* true across almost every account: a test that gets shut off after a day or two of low spend rarely tells you anything real. Budget for a genuine test window, not a single day.

Organic search asks for a different kind of investment: mostly your time (or a freelancer's), spent on research, writing, structure, and patience — rather than an ad account balance.

Where should your next dollar or hour actually go? Use this quick framework:

IF THIS IS TRUE FOR YOU...	...LEAN TOWARD
You don't have consistent, converting product pages yet	Neither — fix conversion first. Traffic to a broken page wastes both channels.
You need revenue in the next 2–4 weeks to keep the business running	Paid (organic is too slow for near-term survival cash flow)
You have more time than spare cash right now	Organic (this workbook)
You have a validated, converting offer and some testing budget	Paid, to scale what's already working, alongside ongoing organic
You're targeting buyers who research heavily before purchasing (higher price point, considered purchase)	Organic tends to punch above its weight here — these buyers search before they see an ad
You're targeting impulse/visual purchases with a lower price point	Paid social often converts faster for this pattern

Most healthy small stores end up doing both, in different proportions at different stages. This workbook is entirely about the organic side — not because paid doesn't work, but because organic is the side you can start building *before* you have a large ad budget, and it doesn't stop compounding while you save up for one.

SEE

Juniper Lane Candle Co. (illustrative numbers only — not real research):

- Average Order Value (AOV): $34
- Gross margin: 62%
- Break-even CAC (what they could spend to acquire a customer on their very first order and still break even): $34 × 62% = **$21.08**

If a paid ad test is currently costing them $35 to acquire a customer, they're underwater on that first order — which isn't automatically bad (many brands accept a loss on order one and make it back on repeat purchases), but it *is* something they need to know and decide about deliberately, not discover by accident three months in.

DO

✎ Worksheet — Your Customer Acquisition Economics

Fill in what you know. Leave blank what you don't — "I don't have this yet" is a valid, useful answer for a new store, and tells you exactly what to start tracking.

Your unit economics

Average Order Value (AOV): $

Gross margin (%):

Break-even CAC (AOV × Gross Margin) = $

(This is the most you could spend to acquire a first-time customer and still break even on that one order — not counting repeat purchases.)

Your paid testing reality (if applicable)

Current or estimated conversion rate on paid traffic:

What you're currently spending (or planning to spend) to test paid ads per month: $

Estimated current CAC from paid channels (spend ÷ new customers), if you have this: $

- Is your estimated CAC above or below your break-even CAC? ☐ Above ☐ Below ☐ Don't know yet

Your organic investment

Hours per week you can realistically commit to SEO/content work:

Any budget for content help (writer, photographer, freelancer): $

- *(There's no "value of an organic conversion" formula to fill in yet — that number only becomes real once you have Search Console data. Section 22 gives you the scorecard to start tracking it.)*

Your one-line decision, right now:

Based on the framework above, where is your next marketing hour or dollar going?

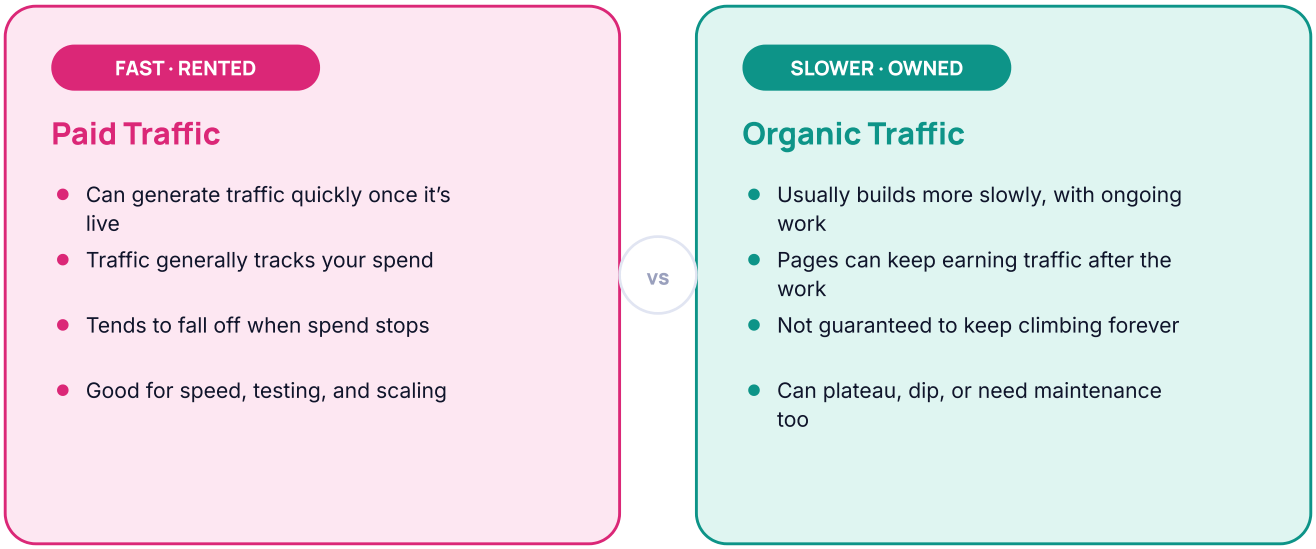
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CHECK YOUR WORK

If your break-even CAC came out very low (under $15–20) and you sell a lower-margin product, that's useful information on its own: it tells you paid acquisition will be a tighter game for you than for a higher-margin brand, and it raises the relative value of organic traffic, which doesn't carry a per-click cost. If you left most fields blank because you're pre-launch, that's fine — revisit this worksheet after your first 20–30 orders, once real numbers exist.

DON'T DO THIS

Don't copy a CAC or ad-budget number you saw in a blog post or forum thread and treat it as your target. Acceptable CAC depends entirely on *your* margin and AOV — a number that's healthy for a $120 skincare brand can be ruinous for a $22 candle brand.



PART 2

02

FIND WHAT PEOPLE ARE SEARCHING FOR

✦ YOUR SYSTEM SO FAR

Part 0 · Your Starting Point → Part 1 · Your Organic Traffic Foundation

YOU ARE HERE

Part 2 — Find What People Are Searching For

Part 3 · Turn Keywords Into a Shopify Store | Part 4 · Content That Actually Supports Sales | + 6 more

SECTION 3

Keyword Research Without Becoming an SEO Expert

LEARN

A **keyword** is just the phrase someone actually types (or says) into a search bar. That's it — the jargon around keyword research is mostly just ways of describing *what kind* of phrase it is:

- **Search volume** — roughly how many times a phrase is searched in a given place over a given time period. You'll usually see this as a range, not an exact number, unless you're paying for premium tool access — and that's genuinely fine for a small store's decision-making.
- **Search intent** — *why* someone is searching, not just what they typed. "What is soy wax" and "buy soy candles" use similar words but want completely different things. (Full breakdown in Section 5.)
- **Commercial intent** — the searcher is close to a purchase decision, comparing or evaluating options ("best non toxic candles").
- **Transactional intent** — the searcher is ready to buy right now ("buy soy candles online").
- **Informational intent** — the searcher wants to learn something, not buy yet ("are soy candles better than paraffin").
- **Branded search** — someone searching your actual business name. If people are typing "Juniper Lane Candle Co," they already know you — that's a different opportunity than someone who's never heard of you.
- **Long-tail search** — longer, more specific phrases ("non toxic soy candle gift set for new homeowners"). These get searched less often individually, but there are vastly more of them, they're usually easier to rank for, and the person searching one is often closer to buying because they know exactly what they want.
- **Search difficulty / competition** — a rough estimate of how hard it would be to rank for a term, usually based on how strong the sites currently ranking for it are.

You do not need to memorize search-volume numbers or become fluent in a paid SEO tool. You need to know roughly what people search for, roughly how many of them, and roughly who else is already showing up when they do. That's genuinely enough for a small store's first strategy.

A few free tools that are actually enough to start:

- **Google Search itself** — search a term and look at autocomplete suggestions as you type, plus the "related searches" and "People also ask" boxes (when they appear) at

the bottom/middle of results. This is free, instant, and shows you real language real searchers use.

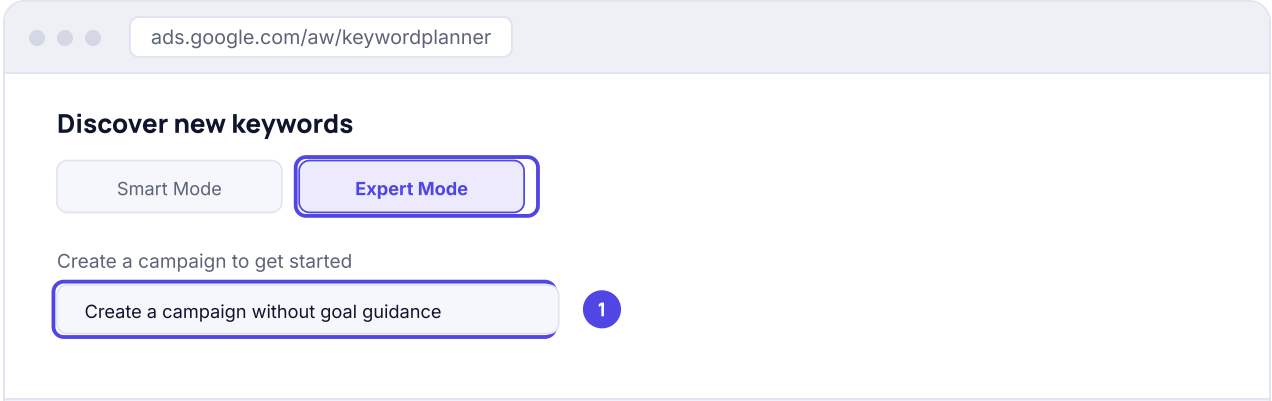
- **Google Trends** (trends.google.com) — free. Shows whether interest in a term is rising, falling, flat, or seasonal. Great for catching things like "fall candles" spiking every September, or spotting a declining trend before you invest in it.
- **Google Keyword Planner** — free, but technically lives inside Google Ads and asks you to create an account. You do **not** have to run or pay for any ads to use it: create the account, start the campaign-creation flow, switch to "Expert Mode" before entering any payment details, choose to create a campaign without goal guidance, then pause it immediately once it's created. This unlocks more specific volume ranges than the "1K–10K"-style estimate you'll see without it.
- **Your own Shopify on-site search data** — if customers can search your store, Shopify tracks what they type. This is one of the only keyword sources that's specific to *your* actual visitors, and it's already sitting in your admin, unused, right now. Check under your analytics/search reports.
- **Google Search Console** — free, but only useful once you have some traffic and history (Section 17 sets this up). Eventually this becomes your single best keyword source, because it shows what people *actually* searched to find you, not what a tool guessed they might search.
- **Bing Webmaster Tools** — free, worth a quick setup once your Google side is handled. Bing is a genuine secondary source of traffic for most stores — small next to Google, but real, and meaningfully stronger on desktop than mobile — and setup takes minutes since it can often import your Google Search Console data.

A fuller comparison of free and low-cost keyword tools — including which ones are actually worth a paid tier for a store your size — is in the Toolkit (Section 27). Don't go shopping for tools yet; the four free ones above are enough for what's next.

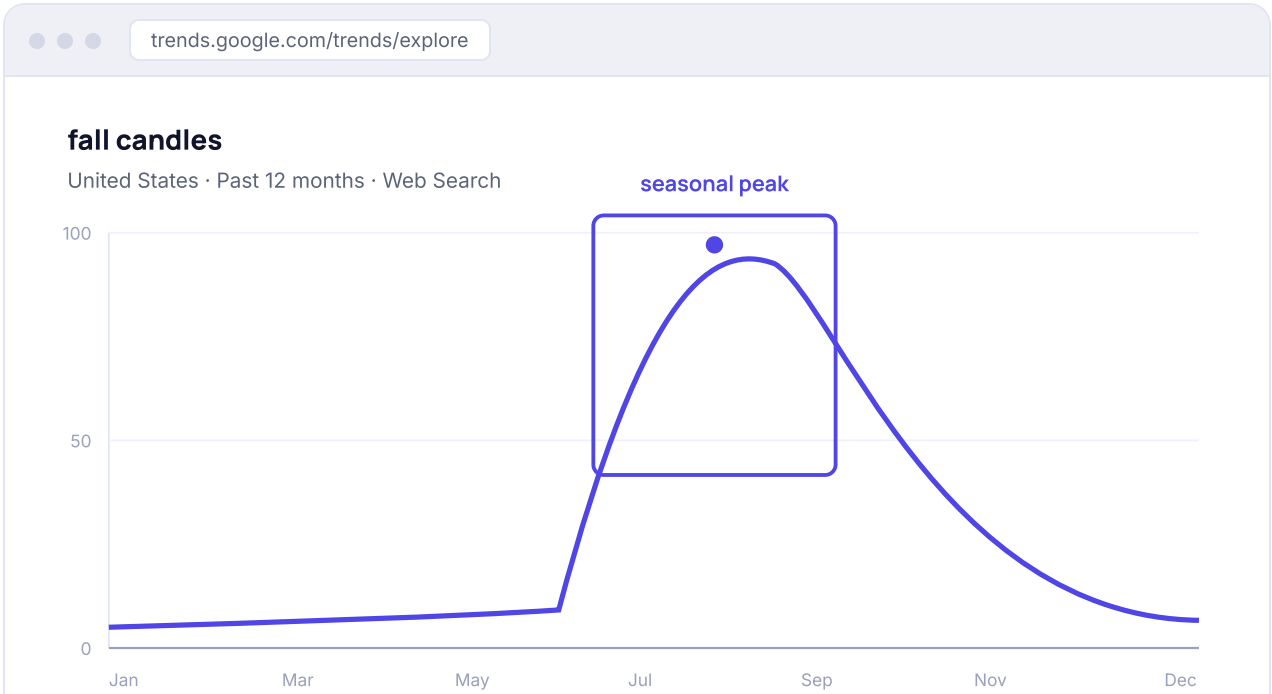
A quick, honest note on competition: you don't need a formal competitor audit to get a feel for how hard a term will be. Open an incognito window, search your target phrase, and look at who shows up on page one. If it's mostly Amazon, Etsy, Target, and huge national brands, that's a genuinely hard term for a small independent store to win head-on any time soon — not impossible, just a longer game. If you see other small, independent stores like yours in the results, that's a much more realistic target — and a real, useful signal for prioritizing where to start.

DO THIS NOW

Open Google Keyword Planner (or just Google Search, if you'd rather start simpler) and search your single best-selling product type. Write down the volume range or the first three autocomplete suggestions you see: _____ This is just a warm-up — the real keyword-building work starts in Section 4.



What you're looking for: the Expert Mode toggle and the “create a campaign without goal guidance” option — this path never asks for billing details.



Interest climbs steadily from August, peaks in early October, then drops off after the holidays.

What you're looking for: the clear seasonal peak — plan seasonal content ahead of a peak like this, not during it.

SECTION 4

Build Your Keyword Universe

LEARN

Most new store owners think about keywords the way they think about their own product page: “candles.” That’s one keyword. It’s also almost certainly one of the hardest, most generic, most competitive terms in your entire space — and it tells you almost nothing about *why* someone’s searching it.

The fix is to expand outward from each core product using thirteen different angles. Not every angle will produce something for every product, and that’s fine — the point is to force yourself past the first obvious term.

ANGLE	QUESTION TO ASK
Product	What is the exact item?
Type	What kind, specifically?
Category	What broader group does it belong to?
Problem	What problem does it solve or avoid?
Benefit	What does the customer get from it?
Material	What’s it made of?
Feature	What does it specifically do or include?
Use case	When/how is it used?
Customer	Who is it for?
Location	Does geography matter (local pickup, region, climate)?
Comparison	What do people weigh it against?
Question	What would someone ask about it before buying?
Season / Gift / Occasion	When or why would someone buy it as a gift or for an occasion?

SEE

Juniper Lane Candle Co.'s “soy candle” expands like this:

ANGLE	EXAMPLE KEYWORDS
Product	candle
Type	soy candle
Category	home fragrance
Problem	candles that trigger headaches / migraines, candles safe for pets
Benefit	non toxic candle, clean burning candle
Material	soy wax candle, cotton wick candle
Feature	reusable jar candle, long burning candle, hand poured candle
Use case	candles for relaxation, candles for meditation, candles for date night
Customer	candles for sensitive skin, candles for new parents
Location	candles made in [city/state], local candle shop [city]
Comparison	soy candle vs paraffin candle, soy wax vs beeswax
Question	are soy candles better for you, do soy candles smell as strong
Season / Gift	fall candles, candles for housewarming gift, candle gift set

One product. Thirteen angles. Dozens of real, specific, far-less-competitive phrases — several of which are also clearly transactional or close to it.

DO

✎ Worksheet — Your Keyword Universe

Pick your top 1–2 products or product types. Work across every angle. Don't skip an angle just because nothing comes to mind immediately — sit with it for thirty seconds before moving on. Aim for at least 2–3 phrases per angle where possible.

Product/type I'm expanding:

ANGLE	YOUR KEYWORDS
Product	
Type	
Category	
Problem	
Benefit	
Material	
Feature	
Use case	
Customer	
Location	
Comparison	
Question	
Season / Gift / Occasion	

Repeat this table for each of your top 2–3 products or product types before moving on. This is the raw material for everything from here forward — your collection strategy, your content plan, and your product-page copy will all draw from this list.

CHECK YOUR WORK

You should end this exercise with at least 30–50 total phrases across your top products. If you have fewer than 15, you likely stopped at the obvious angles (Product, Type, Category) and skipped the ones that take more thought (Problem, Benefit, Use Case, Question) — those are usually where the best, least-competitive opportunities are hiding. Go back and push on those three specifically.

✨ **ASK AI**

Once you've generated your own list by hand, AI can help you expand it further or spot gaps — but it does not know real search volume, and it will sometimes invent plausible-sounding keywords nobody actually searches. Treat its output as more raw material to sanity-check with the free tools from Section 3, not as verified data.

Paste this into ChatGPT or another AI assistant:

> *I sell [your product/type] to [your target customer]. Here are the keywords I've already come up with: [paste your list]. Using these categories — Product, Type, Category, Problem, Benefit, Material, Feature, Use Case, Customer, Location, Comparison, Question, Season/Gift — suggest additional keyword phrases I may have missed in each category. Don't guess at search volume or difficulty — just suggest phrases a real customer might actually type.*

SECTION 5

Search Intent

LEARN

Not every keyword wants the same thing, even when the words look similar. Getting this wrong is one of the most common (and avoidable) mistakes in ecommerce SEO: writing a blog post for a phrase that should have been a product page, or vice versa.

Three intent types cover almost everything:

- **"What is X?" → Informational intent.** The searcher wants to learn, not buy — yet. *"Are soy candles better for you"* wants an honest answer, not a sales pitch. This maps to a **blog article**.
- **"Best X for Y" → Comparison / commercial intent.** The searcher is evaluating options, getting close to a decision. *"Best non toxic candles for headaches"* wants to compare choices. This maps to a **collection page** (a curated "Non-Toxic Candles" collection) or a **buying-guide article** that links into that collection.
- **"Buy X" → Transactional intent.** The searcher is ready to purchase. *"Buy soy candles online"* or *"soy wax candle, lavender, 8oz"* wants a **product page**, fast, with a clear price and an add-to-cart button.

Match the wrong page type to the intent, and you lose the visitor even if you rank: someone with transactional intent who lands on a 1,500-word essay about the history of soy wax will bounce. Someone with informational intent who lands on a bare product page with no context will bounce too.

SEE

KEYWORD	INTENT	SEARCHER WANTS	BEST PAGE TYPE
are soy candles better for you	Informational	An honest, non-salesy answer	Blog article
soy candle vs paraffin candle	Comparison	Help deciding between two options	Blog article, linking to relevant collection
best non toxic candles for headaches	Comparison	A shortlist of real options	Collection page
soy wax candle lavender 8oz	Transactional	To buy this specific item, now	Product page
candles for housewarming gift	Comparison/Transactional (mixed)	Gift ideas, ready to buy soon	Collection page (a “Gift Candles” collection)
Juniper Lane Candle Co	Branded	Already knows the brand	Homepage

DO

✎ Worksheet — Search Intent Classification

Pull 15–20 keywords from your Section 4 keyword universe and classify each one. The “Priority” column is your gut call for now — rank the ones that feel both realistic (not dominated by giant brands) and clearly tied to a sale higher.

KEYWORD	INTENT	SEARCHER WANTS	BEST PAGE TYPE	PRIORITY (1–3)

(Add rows as needed — this table is meant to keep growing as your keyword universe does.)

CHECK YOUR WORK

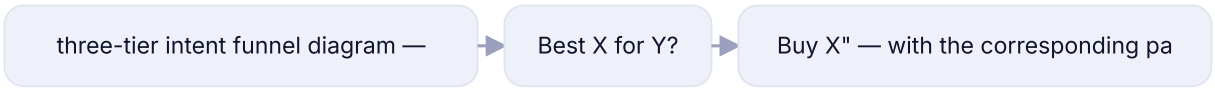
Every keyword you marked “Transactional” should point to a product or collection page you either already have or are planning to build in Part 3. Every keyword marked “Informational” should point to a blog article you’re planning to build in Part 4, and that article should link back to a relevant product or collection page. If a keyword doesn’t clearly point anywhere yet, that’s normal at this stage — Part 3 is where that gets resolved.

✨ **ASK AI**

Paste this into ChatGPT or another AI assistant once you have a longer keyword list than fits comfortably in the table above:

> *Classify each of these keywords by search intent (informational, comparison/commercial, transactional, or branded), tell me what the searcher most likely wants, and suggest the best page type (blog article, collection page, or product page) for each: [paste your keyword list].*

AI is genuinely good at this kind of pattern classification — but intent can be ambiguous, and only a real search (Section 3’s incognito-window check) tells you what’s *actually* ranking for a term today. Spot-check a handful of the AI’s classifications against real Google results before you build your whole content plan around them.



PART 3

03

TURN KEYWORDS INTO A SHOPIFY STORE

✦ YOUR SYSTEM SO FAR

Part 0 · Your Starting Point → Part 1 · Your Organic Traffic Foundation →

Part 2 · Find What People Are Searching For

YOU ARE HERE

Part 3 — Turn Keywords Into a Shopify Store

Part 4 · Content That Actually Supports Sales

Part 5 · On-Page SEO

+ 5 more

This is where the work you did in Part 2 stops being a list and starts being a store.

Before you continue, pull out two things you built:

- Your **Keyword Universe** (Section 4) — every phrase you generated across the 13 angles.
- Your **Search Intent Classification** (Section 5) — where you sorted those phrases by informational / comparison / transactional and matched them to a page type.

Everything in this Part draws directly from those two worksheets. If you skipped ahead without doing them, go back — this Part won't make sense as an abstract exercise.

SECTION 6

Shopify Site Architecture

LEARN

Most new Shopify stores end up structured by accident: homepage, then a pile of products, then a blog nobody planned. That happens because Shopify lets you publish a product or a post without ever forcing you to decide where it fits. Nothing breaks — but nothing helps a customer (or Google) understand what you sell and how it's organized, either.

A search-optimized structure looks like this:

```
Homepage
   ↓
Collections (the major shopping categories a customer would browse)
   ↓
Subcollections (only where a category is genuinely large or varied enough to need one)
   ↓
Products
   ↕
Supporting content (blog articles that answer questions and link back to
the collection or product they support — never orphaned on their own)
```

This structure matters for two audiences at once, for related reasons:

- **Customers** use it to browse — a shopper landing on your "Candles" collection expects to narrow down from there, not hunt through 80 unsorted products.
- **Google** uses your structure (mainly your navigation menu and internal links — more on this in Section 15) to understand what pages matter, how they relate to each other, and what each one is "about." A flat pile of products with no collection structure gives Google very little to work with, even if each individual product page is well-written.

New in 2026 — Shopify subcollections are now native. As of July 16, 2026, Shopify collections can pull in other collections as a source — so a parent collection like "Living Room" can include child collections like "Sofas" and "Armchairs," and it stays automatically up to date as products are added to the children. This used to require navigation-menu tricks, tag-based workarounds, or a third-party app. **If you've read older Shopify SEO advice describing those workarounds, you can ignore it** — go to **Products** → **Collections** → **Add collection**, and when adding a source, choose "Collection" instead of "Products," then connect the child collections you want nested underneath.

> **DON'T DO THIS**
> Don't create subcollections just because Shopify now makes it easy. A new feature isn't a reason to add a layer of navigation. The only good reason to create a subcollection is the same reason to create any collection: real, distinct customer demand for browsing that specific slice of your catalog. If "Living Room" only has 12 products total, it doesn't need three subcollections under it — it needs one clean collection.

CRITICAL CONCEPT: Keywords Do Not Automatically Deserve Pages

This is the mistake that undoes a lot of otherwise-good keyword research: treating every keyword variation you found in Section 4 as its own collection.

Say your keyword universe turned up all of these: *red candles, burgundy candles, dark red candles, wine colored candles*

Creating four separate collections for these would be a mistake — they're almost certainly the same shopper, using different words for the same thing, and four thin, near-identical collections compete with each other for the same searches instead of combining their strength into one.

But not every group of similar-looking keywords should be collapsed, either. Sometimes what looks like a "variation" is actually a genuinely different shopper need. The skill here is telling the difference — and it's worth far more than a rule that just says "make a collection for every keyword."

Run every keyword cluster through these five questions, in order:

1. **Is this the same search intent as a page I'm already planning, just worded differently?** → If yes, stop here. It's supporting language for that page, not a new page.
2. **If it's genuinely different — is the difference something a shopper would filter *within* a collection, or something they'd search for as its own browsing destination?** → Color, size, and scent are usually filters (a shopper narrows down *inside* "Candles," they don't go looking for a whole separate "Burgundy Candles" store section). A genuinely different occasion, use case, or audience ("Candles for Housewarming Gifts") is often worth its own collection.
3. **Does the standalone candidate have enough real, distinct products to not feel thin?** → A collection with 3 products in a catalog of 200 usually isn't a collection — it's either a blog article or a filter.
4. **Is there real search demand for this specific variation**, or did it just come up while brainstorming? → No demand, no page. Not every phrase you generated needs to become a

destination.

5. **Would this page compete with (cannibalize) another page for the same search**, splitting your ranking strength across two weak pages instead of one strong one? → If yes, merge them.

SEE — applying it to *red candles / burgundy candles / dark red candles / wine colored candles*:

QUESTION	ANSWER	VERDICT
Same intent as an existing page?	These are all shoppers looking for a candle in this general color family	Merge
Filter or standalone destination?	Color is a filter — shoppers expect to narrow by color *inside* a scent or candle-type collection	Filter, not a collection
Enough distinct products?	N/A — decided at the filter stage	—
Real demand?	“Red candles” likely has some demand; the others are minor variants of it	Use “red” as the primary filter/attribute term in copy
Cannibalization risk?	High if built as four separate pages	Avoid

Decision: one product attribute (“color: red”), used as a filter and in on-page language — not four collections. Compare that to “Candles for Housewarming Gifts” — a genuinely different shopper occasion, likely with its own real product selection and real search demand: that one earns a collection.

DO

✎ Worksheet — Does This Keyword Deserve Its Own Page?

Take 5–8 keyword clusters from your Section 4/5 worksheets that felt like “maybe this is a collection” candidates. Run each through the five questions.

KEYWORD CLUSTER	SAME INTENT AS EXISTING PAGE?	FILTER OR STANDALONE NEED?	ENOUGH DISTINCT PRODUCTS?	REAL DEMAND?	CANNIBALIZATION RISK?	DECISION
						☐ Collection ☐ Subcollection ☐ Filter/attribute ☐ Supporting content ☐ No page
						☐ Collection ☐ Subcollection ☐ Filter/attribute ☐ Supporting content ☐ No page
						☐ Collection ☐ Subcollection ☐ Filter/attribute ☐ Supporting content ☐ No page
						☐ Collection ☐ Subcollection ☐ Filter/attribute ☐ Supporting content ☐ No page

KEYWORD CLUSTER	SAME INTENT AS EXISTING PAGE?	FILTER OR STANDALONE NEED?	ENOUGH DISTINCT PRODUCTS?	REAL DEMAND?	CANNIBALIZATION RISK?	DECISION
						☐ Collection ☐ Subcollection ☐ Filter/attribute ☐ Supporting content ☐ No page

Every row marked “Collection” or “Subcollection” moves forward into Section 7’s Collection Map. Everything else either becomes on-page language/filters (Sections 8 and 10), a future blog article (Part 4), or gets set aside — and setting something aside is a legitimate outcome, not an incomplete worksheet.

DO

✎ Worksheet — Draw Your Search-Optimized Store

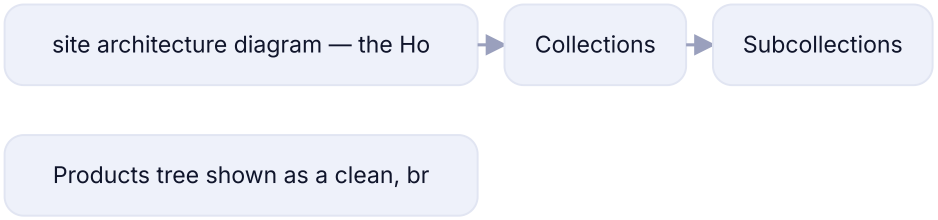
Sketch your structure. Start from the top; you don’t need to fill every branch, and most small stores shouldn’t have more than 2 levels of depth (Collection → Subcollection) — a third level is a sign you’re overcomplicating it.

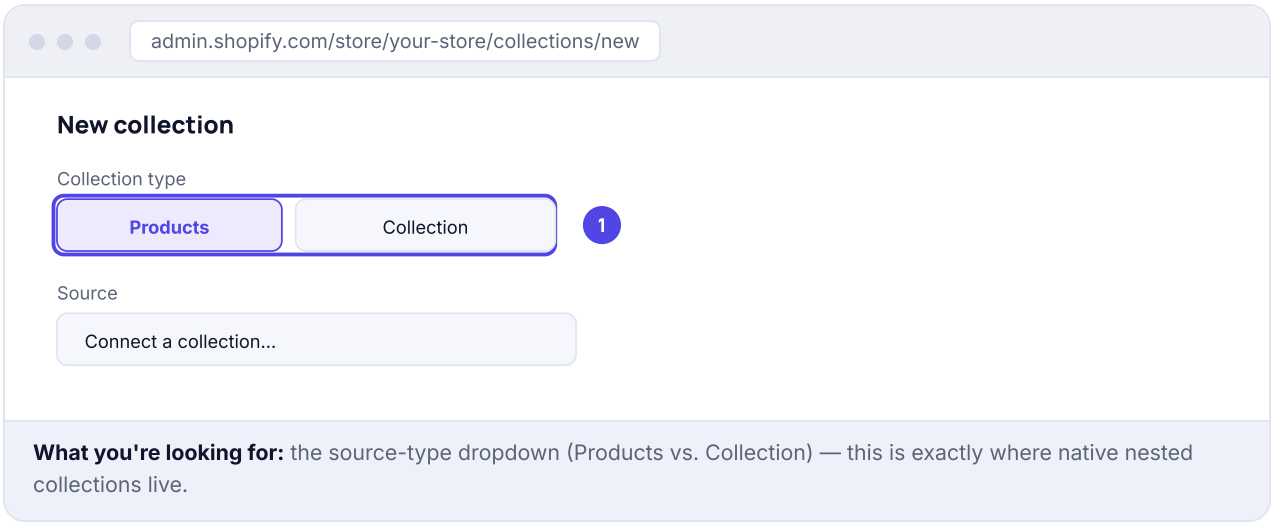
```
HOMEPAGE
  │
  ├── Collection: _____________________  →  Subcollection: _____________________
  │                                      →  Subcollection: _____________________
  │
  ├── Collection: _____________________  →  Subcollection: _____________________
  │                                      →  Subcollection: _____________________
  │
  ├── Collection: _____________________
  │
  └── Collection: _____________________

Supporting content (blog articles) linking into the structure above:
  Article: _____________________  →  links to Collection/Product:
_____________________
  Article: _____________________  →  links to Collection/Product:
_____________________
```

CHECK YOUR WORK

Count your top-level collections. Most small-to-mid Shopify stores land somewhere between 4 and 12 — fewer than that and you're probably under-organized; more than 15–20 top-level collections usually means some of them should be subcollections or should be merged. If any collection on your sketch has fewer than 5 products behind it, revisit it against the five-question framework above before you build it.





What you're looking for: the source-type dropdown (Products vs. Collection) — this is exactly where native nested collections live.

SECTION 7

Collection Strategy

LEARN

Collection pages are one of the most underrated assets in Shopify SEO. A well-built collection page can rank for a broad, valuable search (“non toxic candles”) that no single product page realistically could — because it represents a whole category, has more content and internal links pointing at it, and matches comparison-intent searches directly (remember Section 5: “best X for Y” wants a curated list, which is exactly what a collection is).

A collection deserves to exist when it has all four of these:

- **A real keyword cluster behind it** (from your Section 4–6 work)
- **A distinct search intent** it satisfies
- **Enough genuinely relevant products** to not feel thin
- **A clear reason a customer would want to browse this specific slice of your catalog**, separate from browsing everything

SEE — bad architecture vs. good architecture

Here’s a candle store that did keyword research, got excited, and turned nearly every keyword into a collection:

BAD: `Candles` · `New Arrivals` · `Sale` · `Red Candles` · `Burgundy Candles` · `Wine Candles` · `Fall Candles 2025` · `Fall Candles` · `Best Sellers` · `Gift Ideas` · `Housewarming Candles` · `New Home Gifts`

Problems: “Red/Burgundy/Wine Candles” should be one filterable attribute, not three thin collections. “Fall Candles 2025” and “Fall Candles” are duplicates that will compete with each other every single year. “Gift Ideas,” “Housewarming Candles,” and “New Home Gifts” overlap so heavily a customer (and Google) can’t tell them apart. “New Arrivals,” “Sale,” and “Best Sellers” are useful merchandising collections, but they’re not built around search demand and shouldn’t be treated as SEO assets.

GOOD (same store, consolidated): `Soy Candles` (with a color filter, not separate color collections) · `Non-Toxic Candles` · `Fall Candles` (evergreen URL, refreshed with new products each year instead of rebuilt) · `Candles for Housewarming Gifts` · `Best Sellers` (kept, but understood as a merchandising page, not a keyword target)

Fewer collections. Each one has a clear, distinct reason to exist, a real keyword behind it, and enough products to be worth a visit.

DO

✎ Worksheet — Your Collection Map

Pull every row from Section 6's "Does This Keyword Deserve Its Own Page?" worksheet marked Collection or Subcollection, and build them out here.

KEYWORD CLUSTER	COLLECTION NAME	SUBCOLLECTION? (Y/N, PARENT IF Y)	PRODUCTS (ROUGHLY HOW MANY)	SEARCH INTENT	OVERLAPS ANOTHER COLLECTION?	PRIORITY (1–3)

For each collection, also decide:

- **Collection name:** plain, matches how customers actually search — not a clever internal name. ("Non-Toxic Candles," not "The Clean Burn Collection.")
- **URL handle:** Shopify auto-generates one from the title, but you can edit it under the collection's "Search engine listing" section — keep it short and matching the collection name (`/collections/non-toxic-candles`, not `/collections/collection-4`).
- **Description:** write 2–4 sentences of real, useful copy in the rich-text editor (not a wall of keywords) — this is prime real estate that a lot of stores leave blank entirely, which is a missed opportunity, not a rule you're breaking by skipping it.

CHECK YOUR WORK

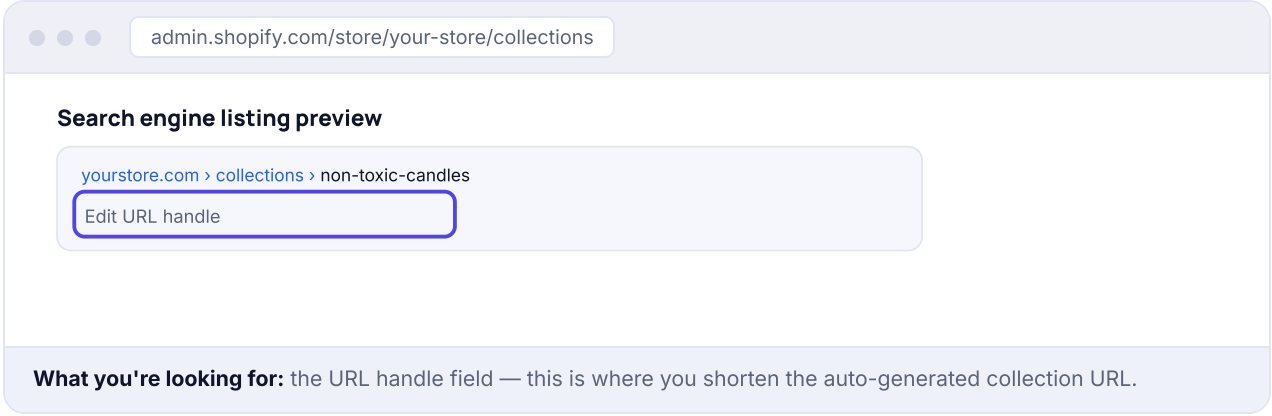
Look at your "Overlaps another collection?" column. Any collection with a "Yes" needs a decision before you build it: merge the two, or clearly differentiate them (different intent, different product set). Two collections quietly competing for the same search is worse than having just one of them.

✨ ASK AI

Paste this into ChatGPT or another AI assistant once you've drafted a collection name and rough product list:

> *I'm building a Shopify collection called '[collection name]' targeting the keyword cluster [paste your keywords]. It will contain these products: [list or describe them]. Write a 2–4 sentence collection description in a [describe your brand voice — e.g., warm and casual / clean and minimal] tone that naturally uses relevant language without keyword stuffing or sounding like a list of search terms.*

Review what it gives you — AI-written collection copy tends to run generic. Rewrite anything that doesn't sound like your actual brand before publishing it.



What you're looking for: the URL handle field — this is where you shorten the auto-generated collection URL.

SECTION 8

Product Page SEO

LEARN

A product page has to do two jobs at once: convince a human to buy, and give Google (and increasingly, AI assistants) enough clear information to understand and recommend it. Done well, these aren't in tension — a page that clearly answers a real shopper's questions is naturally the kind of page that ranks and gets cited.

Before writing anything, answer these seven questions about the specific product you're optimizing:

1. **What is this, exactly?** (Not "a candle" — "an 8oz hand-poured soy candle in a reusable amber glass jar.")
2. **Who is it for?**
3. **Why would they choose this over an obvious alternative** (a cheaper version, a competitor, or not buying at all)?
4. **What specifications actually matter to a buyer** (size, materials, burn time, ingredients, care instructions)?
5. **What questions or doubts might stop someone from buying** — and does the page currently answer them?
6. **What collection or category does this product belong to** — and does the page link there?
7. **What words do real customers use** for this product — from your Section 4 keyword universe, not internal product-naming jargon?

Your answers to these seven questions become the actual content of the page. Here's where each one lands:

PAGE ELEMENT	COMES FROM	NOTES
Product title	Q1, Q7	Lead with what it is in customer language, not a SKU-style internal name. "8oz Soy Candle – Amber Jar, Sandalwood," not "SW-8OZ-AMB."
URL handle	Q1	Shopify auto-generates from the title; edit it in "Search engine listing" to keep it short and clean.
H1 / page heading	Usually matches the title	This is the on-page headline, separate from the browser-tab title.
Product description	Q1–Q5	Real, specific copy — not a bullet dump of keywords. Answer the "why choose this" question explicitly.

PAGE ELEMENT	COMES FROM	NOTES
Images + alt text	Q1, Q7	Alt text should describe what's actually in the image, in plain language, under ~125 characters — not a keyword list. Edit it by opening the image in the product's media section.
Specifications	Q4	A clean, scannable list or table — dimensions, materials, care, what's included.
FAQs	Q5	See the important note below before you write these.
Internal links	Q6	Link to the collection this product belongs to, and to any related supporting blog content.
Metadata (page title & meta description)	Q1, Q7	Under "Search engine listing" — up to 70 characters for the title; the meta description doesn't directly affect ranking but strongly affects whether someone clicks your result over a competitor's.

IMPORTANT

Google discontinued FAQ rich results in Google Search in 2026 — so adding FAQ content or FAQ schema will **not** get you the little expandable question boxes in search results anymore, and you shouldn't build FAQs expecting that outcome. FAQs are still genuinely worth including on a product page, for a different reason: they answer real pre-purchase objections (Q5 above), improve the page for actual readers, and give AI assistants and search engines clearer, more complete information about the product when they're trying to summarize or recommend it. Build FAQs to remove doubt and add clarity — not to chase a search-result feature that no longer exists. On Shopify specifically, you can build FAQs natively using **metafields** (a free, built-in feature on every plan — no app required) to store question/answer pairs, then connect them to a theme section using the theme editor's "dynamic source" option. If you want a more polished, pre-built FAQ layout without touching metafields yourself, a dedicated FAQ block app is a reasonable, low-cost option — but it's optional, not required.

DON'T DO THIS

Don't repeat your main keyword five times across the title, description, and alt text just because you can. Say it naturally, once or twice, where it actually belongs. A product description that reads like it was written for a search engine instead of a person will hurt conversions — and Google is specifically good at recognizing (and not rewarding) that pattern.

SEE — Juniper Lane Candle Co., fully worked example

Product: 8oz hand-poured soy candle, sandalwood scent

ELEMENT	BEFORE (GENERIC)	AFTER (OPTIMIZED)
Title	"Sandalwood Candle"	"8oz Soy Candle – Sandalwood, Hand-Poured in Reusable Amber Jar"
URL	`/products/product-14`	`/products/sandalwood-soy-candle-8oz`

ELEMENT	BEFORE (GENERIC)	AFTER (OPTIMIZED)
Description opening line	“A lovely candle for your home.”	“A warm, woodsy sandalwood candle hand-poured in small batches using 100% soy wax — no paraffin, no synthetic dyes, and safe to burn around pets. Burns 45+ hours in a reusable amber glass jar you’ll want to keep.”
Alt text (main image)	“IMG_4021.jpg” (blank)	“8oz amber glass jar candle with sandalwood label, lit, on a wood shelf”
FAQ example	*(none)*	“Is this candle safe for pets? Yes — our soy wax candles are made without the synthetic fragrances and paraffin byproducts that can bother pets and people with sensitivities.”
Internal link	*(none)*	Links to the “Non-Toxic Candles” collection and to a supporting article, “Are Soy Candles Better For You?”

DO

✎ Worksheet — Optimize One Product With Me

Pick one real product from your store — ideally one tied to a priority keyword cluster from Section 5 or 7. Answer the seven questions, then fill in each field below.

The seven questions, for this product:

1. What is this, exactly?

2. Who is it for?

3. Why choose this over an alternative?

4. Specifications that matter:

5. Questions/doubts that might stop a purchase:

6. Collection/category it belongs to:

7. Real customer language for this product (from your keyword universe):

The page itself:

Product title:

URL handle: `/products/`

Description (2–4 sentences, answering Q1–Q5 in your brand voice):

Image alt text (main image):

One FAQ this page should answer:

Internal link(s) this page should include:

SEO page title (≤70 characters):

Meta description:

✎ REPEATABLE CATALOG CHECKLIST — use this for every other product

- [ ] Title leads with what it is, in customer language
- [ ] URL handle is short, clean, and matches the title
- [ ] Description answers “why choose this,” not just “what is this”
- [ ] Every image has real, specific alt text (not blank, not a filename)
- [ ] Specifications are scannable, not buried in a paragraph
- [ ] At least one FAQ addresses a real purchase objection
- [ ] Page links to its collection and any relevant supporting content
- [ ] Page title and meta description are filled in under “Search engine listing,” not left as Shopify’s default
- [ ] No keyword is repeated more than 2–3 times across the whole page

✨ ASK AI

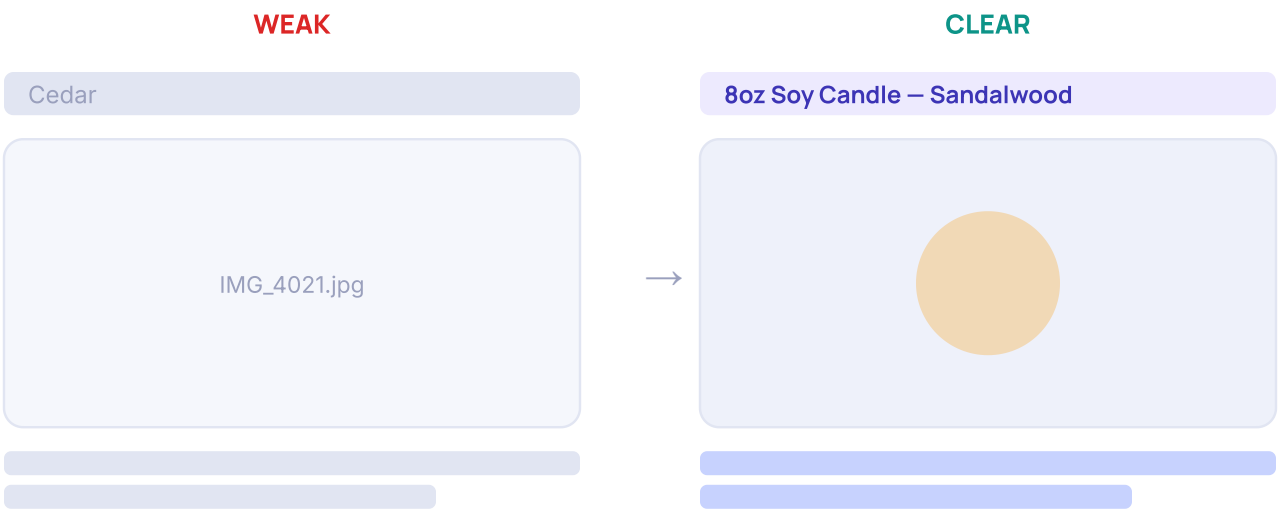
Paste this in once you’ve answered the seven questions above for a product:

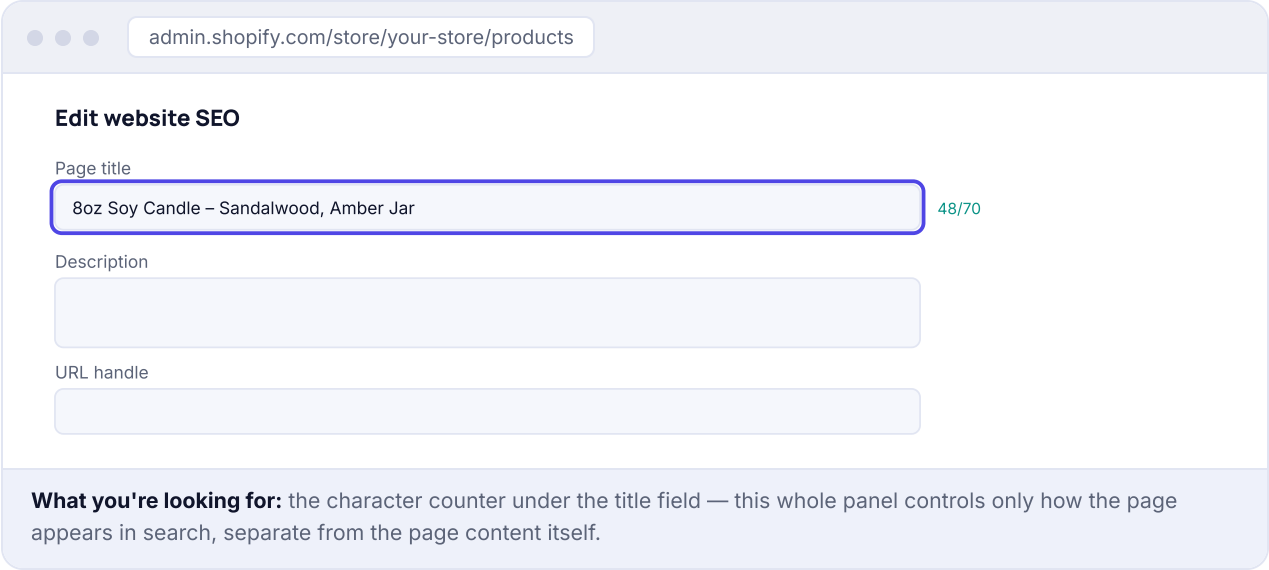
> *Here’s information about my product: [paste your answers to the 7 questions above]. Write a product description in a [your brand voice] tone that naturally covers what it is, who it’s for, and why someone would choose it — without keyword stuffing or generic marketing filler. Keep it to 3–5 sentences.*

This works from information *you* provide — it isn’t inventing product facts, and you should never let it. Check anything it writes against what’s actually true about your product before publishing.

CHECK YOUR WORK

Read your finished description out loud. If it sounds like something you’d actually say to a customer standing in front of you, it’s working. If it sounds like a list of search terms wearing a sentence’s clothing, revise it.





What you're looking for: the character counter under the title field — this whole panel controls only how the page appears in search, separate from the page content itself.



What you're looking for: the alt text field — it's edited per image, not once for the whole product.

SECTION 9

Google Product Visibility (Merchant Center & Free Listings)

LEARN

You just finished optimizing a product page for search engines and shoppers. There's a second, separate system worth understanding: Google can also learn about your products through **structured product data** — a feed of facts about each item — rather than only by reading your webpage. Getting your product page right (Section 8) and getting your product *data* right are related but genuinely different tasks, and this section is the second one.

Two overlapping but different systems:

	TRADITIONAL ORGANIC SEO	PRODUCT / SHOPPING DISCOVERY
What Google evaluates	Your webpage's content, structure, and code	Structured product data you submit (title, price, availability, images, and more)
Where it can appear	Standard search results	Google's Shopping tab, Google Images, Google Lens, Google Maps, YouTube, and Google's AI-powered search experiences — what Google calls "free listings"
Cost	Free	Free (this section) — paid Shopping ads are a separate, optional system layered on top of the same data, and this section isn't about them

Both systems can run at the same time, off the same store, and reinforce each other — but one doesn't substitute for the other. A page can be perfectly optimized (Section 8) and still be invisible on Google's Shopping tab if the underlying product *data* is incomplete or inaccurate.

What Google Merchant Center is

Merchant Center is Google's free tool for managing the product information Google uses across these surfaces. You don't buy anything to use it — you connect it, feed it accurate data, and Google decides whether each product is eligible to appear.

Connecting Shopify to Merchant Center

1. In your Shopify admin, click the **+** next to **Sales channels**, search for **"Google & YouTube,"** and add it.
2. Connect a Google account — use a dedicated business account if you have one, not a personal Gmail, since this account will effectively represent your store to Google going forward.
3. The app automatically verifies your domain (it adds a small verification tag to your site for you — no code editing required).
4. Confirm your shipping settings match what you actually offer.

5. Your product feed syncs automatically — expect the first sync to take anywhere from a few hours up to a day.
6. Review any disapproved products (Google's review can take several business days) and fix what it flags.

Free listings — what they are, and what they aren't

Once connected, eligible products can appear across Google's free surfaces at no cost — no bid, no budget, no click charge. This is genuinely free visibility, separate from anything you'd pay for. To qualify, Google generally expects:

- A Merchant Center account in good standing
- Your store to be in a supported country
- Accurate, complete shipping information
- Your core store policies (returns, contact information) clearly visible on your site — the same trust signals mentioned back in Section 1
- Compliance with Google's content and business policies
- Business verification completed — an unverified account won't appear in these results at all

None of this requires a Google Ads account or any ad spend. **Paid Shopping ads are a separate, optional layer** that uses this same underlying product data to run paid placements — worth knowing exists, but outside the scope of a free-discovery workbook like this one.

The product data that actually matters

Much of this will feel familiar from Section 8 — the same instinct (be clear, be accurate, don't stuff keywords) applies here, just applied to structured data instead of page copy.

FIELD	WHAT MATTERS	NOTES
Title	Describe what it is in the words a shopper would actually use — type, key attributes, variant details where relevant	Same principle as Section 8's product title — clarity, not a keyword pile
Description	Accurate, human-written — pulled from or consistent with your actual product page	Don't write a different story here than the one on your site
Category	Google assigns products to its own category system, separate from your Shopify collections	You don't need to master Google's full category list — just make sure your title/description are specific enough for Google to categorize you correctly

FIELD	WHAT MATTERS	NOTES
Identifiers (GTIN, brand, MPN)	Include a real GTIN if your product has one (assigned by a manufacturer)	**Never invent one.** For genuinely handmade, custom, or small-batch products with no manufacturer-assigned GTIN — like a small-batch candle — Shopify/Google have a legitimate way to say "this product doesn't have one": marking that no identifier exists, rather than making one up. A fabricated GTIN can get a product disapproved and create bigger problems than having none.
Price & availability	Must match what's actually on your store	A feed showing $39/In Stock while your store shows $49/Out of Stock is exactly the kind of mismatch that gets a product flagged — not framed as a "penalty," just a data conflict Google won't resolve in your favor
Variants	Each meaningful variant (size, color, material) is generally represented separately in the data Shopify sends	Mostly handled automatically once connected — this is owner-level awareness, not something you build by hand
Images	Clear, accurate, well-lit product photos — the product should be easy to actually see	Avoid heavy promotional text/overlays on the primary image if your listings seem to be getting flagged for it; supplementary lifestyle or detail images are fine as extras, not replacements for a clean primary shot
Shipping & returns	Configured accurately in Merchant Center to match your real policies	Feeds directly into the trust/eligibility check above

Data consistency is the concept to remember

Your product page, any structured data on that page (Section 18 covers this briefly — not re-taught here), and your Merchant Center feed should all tell the same story about a product. They don't have to be worded identically, but the *facts* — price, availability, what it is — need to agree. Structured data on your page can help Google understand a product; it does not, on its own, guarantee Shopping visibility. That's still governed by your actual Merchant Center data and eligibility status.

Where to check your status

In Google Merchant Center's current interface, go to **Products** → **Needs attention** to see which products have an issue, ranked by how much visibility they're likely losing. Click any flagged item for the specific reason. Here's the thing worth internalizing: **a product existing in your Shopify catalog does not mean it's automatically eligible or approved to appear on Google's product surfaces.** Connecting the channel is the start, not the finish — it's worth a periodic check, the same way you periodically check Search Console.

SEE — Juniper Lane, weak vs. clear product data

	WEAK	CLEARER
Title	“Cedar”	“8oz Soy Wax Candle — Cedar & Sandalwood, Hand-Poured”
Identifier	*(fabricated a GTIN that doesn’t really belong to this product)*	Marked as having no manufacturer identifier — accurate, since this is a small-batch handmade candle
Price/availability	Feed says $32, store checkout shows $34	Both show $34

No search-volume or ranking claim attached to any of this — the point is that Google (and a shopper) can tell exactly what this product is and trust that the price/availability shown is real.

DO

✎ Worksheet — Google Product Visibility Checklist

Setup

- [ ] Google & YouTube channel connected in Shopify
- [ ] Domain verified
- [ ] Products actively syncing
- [ ] Free listings status checked in Merchant Center

Product data

- [ ] Titles are descriptive and specific, not generic (like “Cedar” alone)
- [ ] Descriptions match what’s actually on the product page
- [ ] Identifiers are accurate — real GTIN where one exists, correctly marked as “no identifier” where it genuinely doesn’t (never fabricated)
- [ ] Variants (size/color/material) are represented correctly
- [ ] Price matches your live store exactly
- [ ] Availability matches your live store exactly

Images

- [ ] Primary image clearly shows the actual product
- [ ] No heavy promotional text/overlay on the primary image

Trust / policy

- [ ] Shipping information is accurate and complete
- [ ] Returns policy is accurate and visible on your site
- [ ] Required business/contact information is visible on your site

Health

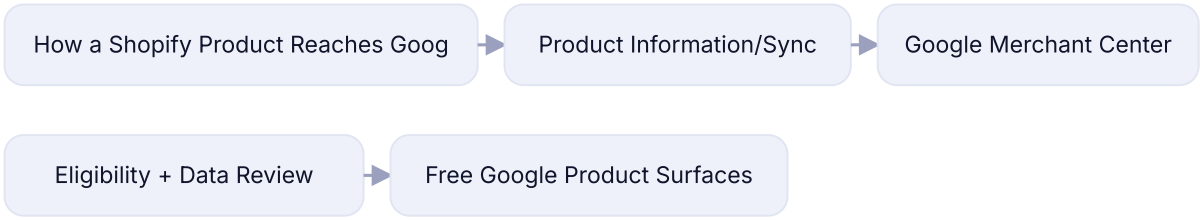
- [ ] Checked Products → Needs attention for flagged issues
- [ ] Reviewed and addressed any disapprovals
- [ ] Confirmed no price/availability mismatches between store and feed

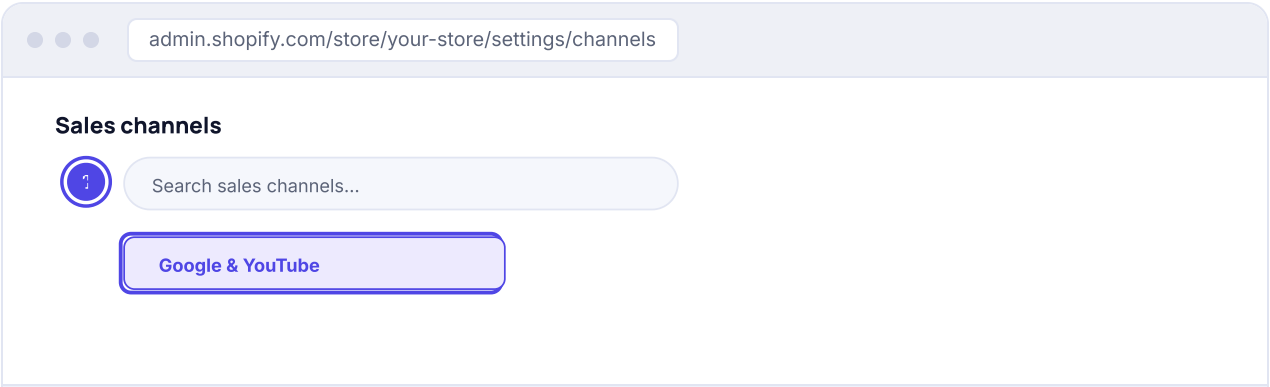
CHECK YOUR WORK

If you’re seeing disapprovals, start with the highest-click-potential items first (Merchant Center ranks them for you) — fixing your best-selling product’s data matters more right now than fixing a rarely-viewed one.

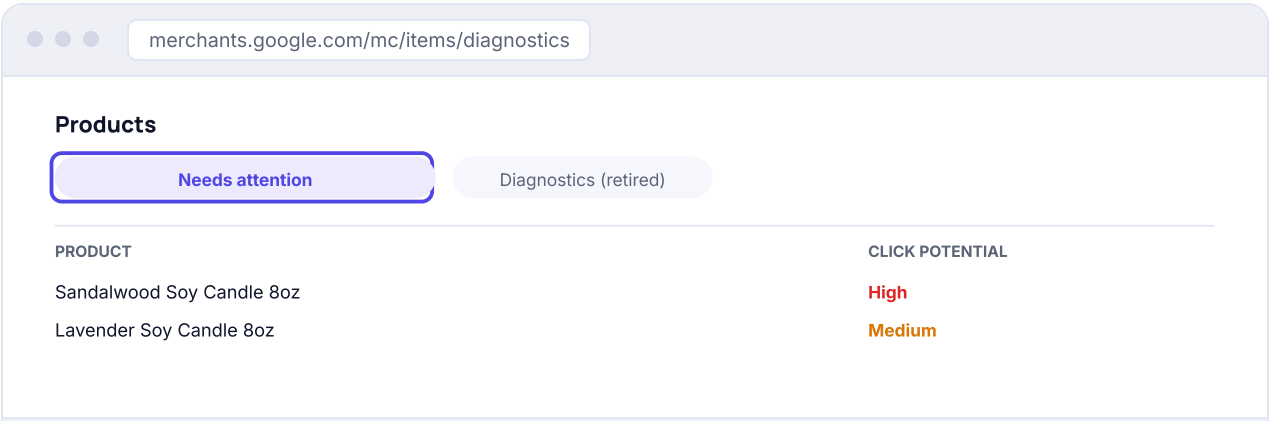
IMPORTANT PRODUCT BOUNDARY

This section covers what a store owner can reasonably check and fix themselves. Deep feed troubleshooting, managing paid Shopping campaigns, and advanced Merchant Center configuration are their own specialty — genuinely useful to know exists, not something this workbook is trying to turn you into an expert at.





What you're looking for: the + icon and channel search — this is the entire connection point, no app-store purchase required.



What you're looking for: the “Needs attention” tab and click-potential ranking — this is the current home for product issues; older tutorials calling this “Diagnostics” describe a retired interface.

SECTION 10

Collection Page SEO

LEARN

Everything from Section 8 applies to collection pages too, with one difference: a collection page is selling a *category*, not one item — so its job is to help someone confidently narrow down, not to close a single sale.

DO

✎ Worksheet — Optimize Your Highest-Priority Collection

Pull your #1 priority collection from Section 7's Collection Map.

Collection name:

URL handle: `/collections/`

Description (2–4 sentences — what's in this collection and who it's for):

What makes this collection different from a similar/nearby one (if any)?

Products currently in it (rough count):

Internal links this page should include (related collections, a supporting article):

SEO page title (≤70 characters):

Meta description:

CHECK YOUR WORK

If you can't write a description that clearly says what makes this collection different from another one in your store, that's a sign from Section 6–7's framework worth revisiting — you may have a collection that should be merged, not one that needs better copy.

PART 4

04

CONTENT THAT ACTUALLY SUPPORTS SALES

✦ YOUR SYSTEM SO FAR

Part 0 · Your Starting Point → Part 1 · Your Organic Traffic Foundation →

Part 2 · Find What People Are Searching For → Part 3 · Turn Keywords Into a Shopify Store

YOU ARE HERE

Part 4 — Content That Actually Supports Sales

Content Clusters | 30 Content Opportunities

Part 5 · On-Page SEO | Part 6 · Technical SEO Without the Tech Overload | + 4 more

Here's what you've built so far, in order:

```
Keyword Universe (Sec. 4)  →  Search Intent (Sec. 5)  →  Site Architecture (Sec. 6)
     →  Collection Map (Sec. 7)  →  One Optimized Product Page (Sec. 8)
```

That's your commercial foundation — the pages designed to make a sale. This Part adds the layer around it: content that answers the questions your commercial pages can't answer on their own, and sends that traffic back into the store. By the end of Part 4, your system extends to:

```
     →  Content Clusters (Sec. 12)  →  30 Prioritized Content Opportunities (Sec. 13)
```

SECTION 11

Stop Writing Random Blog Posts

LEARN

"Post consistently" is common advice. It's also not a strategy — it's a schedule. A store that publishes 4 blog posts a month with no connection to what it sells has *content*, but it doesn't have a *content strategy*. The difference matters, because every piece of content you publish is something you now have to write, host, keep accurate, and eventually maintain or retire. Publishing should be a deliberate decision, not a habit filling a calendar slot.

Before you write anything, run the idea through six questions:

1. **What is the searcher trying to learn or accomplish?**
2. **Does this topic relate to something I actually sell?**
3. **Which commercial page (product or collection) does this content support?**
4. **Where should the reader go after they get their answer?** (If the honest answer is "nowhere," reconsider the topic.)
5. **Does a useful page on this topic already exist** — on your site or elsewhere — that you'd just be duplicating?
6. **Am I creating this because real customer questions or search demand point to it, or because I needed something to post this week?**

If you can't answer Questions 2–4 with something specific, the idea isn't ready yet — not necessarily wrong, just not yet connected to your business.

Content has jobs. Not every article's job is "convince someone to buy right now" — but every article should have *a* job, and you should know what it is before you write it:

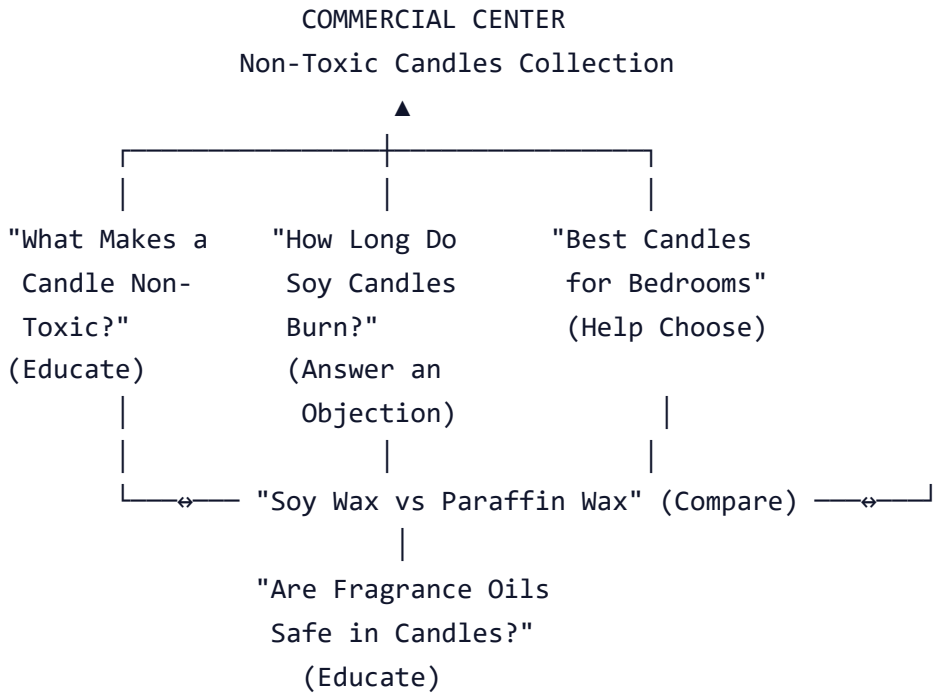
JOB	WHAT IT DOES	JUNIPER LANE EXAMPLE
Educate	Explains a concept a customer might not know	"What Is a Soy Candle?"

JOB	WHAT IT DOES	JUNIPER LANE EXAMPLE
Compare	Helps someone choose between two known options	“Soy vs. Paraffin Candles”
Help Choose	Guides a decision within your own catalog	“How to Choose a Candle for a Bedroom”
Solve a Problem	Fixes a real frustration (often post-purchase)	“Why Is My Candle Tunneling?”
Answer an Objection	Removes a specific doubt that blocks a purchase	“Do Soy Candles Last Longer?”
Capture Seasonal/Occasion Demand	Meets a recurring, time-bound search pattern	“Best Candles for Housewarming Gifts”
Support a Commercial Category	Builds authority around a whole collection	“Best Non-Toxic Candles for Your Home”

Not every piece needs to pitch a product directly — “Why Is My Candle Tunneling?” is genuinely useful to someone who already owns a candle (yours or not), and that’s fine. Its job isn’t a hard sell; its job is to be the kind of genuinely helpful page that builds trust, earns a link back to your site from someone else, and keeps a customer coming back to a brand that clearly knows what it’s talking about. The content *ecosystem*, taken as a whole, should connect logically to your business — not every single article in isolation.

SEE — a topical cluster, built around a commercial page

A topical cluster is a small group of supporting articles built around one commercial page, each with a job, each linking back.



Every supporting article has an arrow pointing back up to the collection it supports — that's the internal link that turns a helpful read into a store visit (Section 15 covers exactly how to build that link well; this section is about knowing *which* article should exist and *why*, not the mechanics of the link itself). Where two articles are closely related to each other — like "Soy Wax vs Paraffin Wax" naturally connecting to "What Makes a Candle Non-Toxic?" — they can link sideways to each other too, not just up to the collection.



DON'T DO THIS

Publishing 300 thin, disconnected articles is not a stronger strategy than publishing 20 genuinely useful, well-connected ones. Every page you publish is a page you're responsible for keeping accurate and relevant — a large pile of unconnected content is a maintenance burden with no strategy behind it, not an asset.

DO THIS NOW

Pick one blog post idea you've been sitting on (or one you've already published). Run it through the six questions above. If you land on "I'm not sure which commercial page this supports," hold onto that — Section 12 will resolve it.

SECTION 12

Build Your Content Clusters

LEARN

Now you'll build 3–5 real clusters using the commercial architecture you already have. This isn't a new brainstorm — pull out your **Keyword Universe** (Section 4), **Search Intent Classification** (Section 5), and **Collection Map** (Section 7). Every cluster starts from a commercial page you've already decided matters.

Prioritizing which cluster to build first

You won't build all 3–5 clusters at once, so you need a simple way to decide where to start. Resist the urge to build a precise-looking scoring formula here — a number like "7.4 out of 10" implies a level of certainty this data doesn't actually support. A plain **High / Medium / Low** rating, judged against these factors, is more honest and just as useful:

- **Commercial importance** — does this support one of your top-priority collections (Section 7), or a minor one?
- **Evidence of real demand** — do you have actual search terms, customer questions, or reviews pointing here (vs. a topic that just sounds interesting)?
- **Content gap** — is this poorly covered elsewhere, or would you be the fifth store writing "What Is a Soy Candle"?
- **Your ability to say something genuinely useful** — do you have real expertise, product data, or a customer story here, or would you be guessing?
- **Timing** — is there a seasonal or occasion-based window this needs to land before?
- **Effort required** — realistically, can you produce this well with the time you have?

A cluster that's High on commercial importance and demand, even if it takes more effort, usually beats a Low-effort cluster nobody's searching for.

DO

✎ Worksheet — Your Content Clusters

Build 3–5 clusters. Start each one from a commercial page in your Collection Map or your one optimized product (Section 8) — not from a topic you find personally interesting.

Cluster 1

Commercial page it supports:

Primary commercial topic/keyword:

- Overall cluster priority: ☐ High ☐ Medium ☐ Low

SUPPORTING TOPIC	SEARCH INTENT	CONTENT JOB	INTERNAL-LINK DESTINATION	PRIORITY

(Copy this template for Clusters 2 through 5. A cluster with only one supporting topic is thin — aim for at least 2–4 per cluster, but a smaller, real cluster beats a padded one.)

✨ **ASK AI**

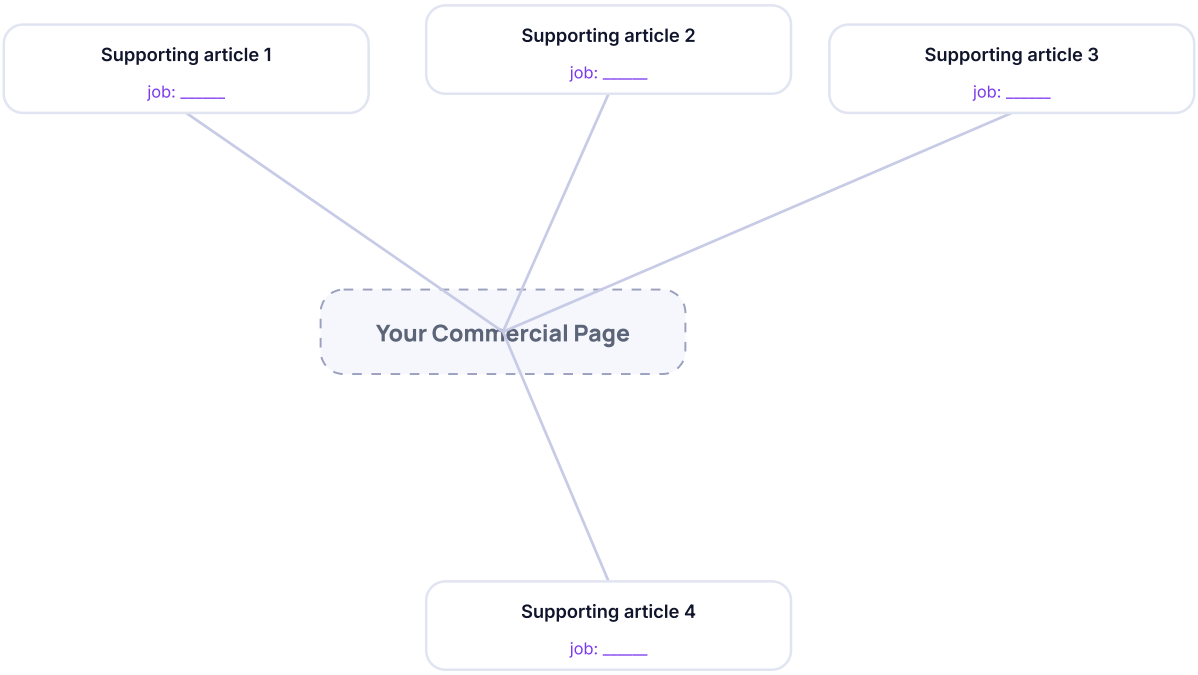
Once you've named a commercial page and started listing supporting topics, use AI to help fill gaps — not to invent the whole cluster from nothing:

> *I sell [commercial page/collection, e.g., 'Non-Toxic Candles'] and I've already identified these supporting content topics: [list what you have]. Suggest 3–5 additional supporting article topics that would genuinely help a customer researching this category, each with the 'job' it would do (educate, compare, help choose, solve a problem, answer an objection, capture seasonal demand, or support the category).*

Treat the output as candidates, not a final list — run each suggestion through Section 11's six questions before adding it to your cluster.

CHECK YOUR WORK

Every supporting topic should have a specific internal-link destination filled in — if you can't say where it links, it's not ready to build yet. And every cluster should trace back to something in your Collection Map or optimized product; if a cluster doesn't connect to anything from Batch 2, that's a sign it belongs in a "maybe later" list, not your first 3–5.


Supporting article 1
job: _____
Supporting article 2
job: _____
Supporting article 3
job: _____
Your Commercial Page
Supporting article 4
job: _____

SECTION 13

Create 30 Content Opportunities

LEARN

"Ask AI for 30 blog ideas" produces 30 plausible-sounding titles. It does not produce 30 *opportunities* — because AI, on its own, has no idea what your actual customers ask, search, or struggle with. Real content opportunities come from real evidence. Here's where to find it, and what each source is actually good for:

SOURCE	USEFUL FOR	CAUTION
Google autocomplete	Seeing how people phrase related searches, in their own words	Reflects popularity, not your specific audience
People Also Ask (when it appears in results)	Real questions Google associates with a search	Still an active feature in 2026, but AI Overviews now often take the more prominent spot on the page above it — treat it as one signal, not the whole picture
Google Search Console (once you have data — Section 17)	The single best source once it exists: what people *actually* searched to find your real pages	Takes time to accumulate meaningful data on a new store
Google Trends	Confirming a topic is rising or seasonal, not declining	Shows relative interest, not exact search counts
Reddit / community discussions	Recurring questions and the exact language real people use when they're not trying to sound like a customer	A busy Reddit thread proves people **discuss** something — it is not proof of meaningful Google search volume. Use it for language and questions, not as a demand estimate.
Competitor content	Spotting topics they cover repeatedly, questions they answer, and gaps where their content is thin	Never copy or closely paraphrase what you find — see the note below
Customer questions (support emails, DMs, in-person)	Some of the highest-quality content ideas you'll find — these are proven objections and confusions from real buyers	Small sample size on a new store — weight recurring questions more than one-off ones
Product reviews	Real language, use cases, and objections customers volunteer unprompted	Look for patterns across multiple reviews, not one outlier comment

SOURCE	USEFUL FOR	CAUTION
Social search (comments/questions on your TikTok, Instagram, etc.)	What your specific audience asks in a lower-pressure setting than a purchase decision	Platform-specific language — may not translate directly to Google search phrasing
Your Shopify site search data	What visitors search for once they're already on your site	Tells you what current visitors want, not what non-visitors are searching for elsewhere

> **NOTE**
>
> studying competitor content means noticing *patterns* — topics they return to, questions they answer well, formats that seem to work, and gaps where their coverage is thin or outdated. It does not mean copying an article, running a competitor's post through AI to "rewrite" it, or assuming a topic is worth targeting just because a competitor covered it — you have no way of knowing whether their article actually performs well. Use what you observe as a starting hypothesis to validate with your own evidence, not as a target to imitate.

From idea to opportunity

A raw idea is a topic with nothing behind it: *"write about candle care."* A qualified **opportunity** has evidence, a clear intent, and a place to go:

FIELD	EXAMPLE
Topic	Why does my candle tunnel?
Evidence	Recurring customer support question + shows up in autocomplete
Intent	Problem-solving
Content job	Solve a Problem
Format	Troubleshooting guide
Commercial page supported	Candle care / relevant candle collection
Priority	High

DO

✎ Worksheet — My First 30 Organic Content Opportunities

Work through six rounds of five. Don't try to qualify each idea as you go — just capture raw ideas first, then qualify the full list at the end. Five per round keeps this from becoming an overwhelming open-ended brainstorm.

Round 1 — Search Suggestions (Google autocomplete, People Also Ask, Google Trends)

1. _

2. _

3. _

4. _

5. _

Round 2 — Customer Questions (support emails, DMs, in-person questions)

1. _

2. _

3. _

4. _

5. _

Round 3 — Reviews & Communities (your product reviews, Reddit, forums)

1. _

2. _

3. _

4. _

5. _

Round 4 — Competitors (patterns and gaps, not copying)

1. _

2. _

3. _

4. _

5. _

Round 5 — Social Search (questions/comments on your social content)

1. _

2. _

3. _

4. _

5. _

Round 6 — Existing Data & Gaps (Search Console once available, site search data, obvious gaps in your Section 12 clusters)

1. _

2. _

3. _

4. _

5. _

Now qualify your strongest 10–15 into real opportunities:

TOPIC	EVIDENCE	INTENT	CONTENT JOB	FORMAT	COMMERCIAL PAGE SUPPORTED	PRIORITY

TOPIC	EVIDENCE	INTENT	CONTENT JOB	FORMAT	COMMERCIAL PAGE SUPPORTED	PRIORITY

✨ **ASK AI**

Two genuinely useful prompts once you have real raw material — not before:

To organize what you found:

> *Here are 30 raw content topic ideas I collected from real search suggestions, customer questions, reviews, and competitor research: [paste your list]. Group these into logical themes, flag any that are near-duplicates of each other, and suggest which of my existing content clusters (if any) each one might belong to: [paste your Section 12 cluster names].*

To turn customer questions into content angles:

> *Here are real questions/comments from my customers: [paste actual customer questions, reviews, or support messages]. For each one, suggest a content angle that would genuinely answer it, and what 'job' that content would do (educate, compare, help choose, solve a problem, answer an objection, capture seasonal demand, or support a category).*

Both prompts work on evidence you already gathered — neither one asks AI to invent search volume, guess at what's trending, or fabricate customer language it doesn't actually have.

CHECK YOUR WORK

Look at your qualified table's Priority column. If everything is "High," you haven't actually prioritized — go back and be honest about which ones are genuinely tied to a commercial page and real evidence versus which ones just sounded good. Your first 3–5 published pieces should come from the highest-priority rows that also map to your Section 12 clusters — that overlap is exactly what "strategy" means here, as opposed to a random list of blog ideas.

PART 5

ON-PAGE SEO

05

✦ YOUR SYSTEM SO FAR

- Part 0 · Your Starting Point
- Part 1 · Your Organic Traffic Foundation
- Part 2 · Find What People Are Searching For
- Part 3 · Turn Keywords Into a Shopify Store
- Part 4 · Content That Actually Supports Sales

YOU ARE HERE

Part 5 — On-Page SEO

On-Page Anatomy · Internal Linking

Part 6 · Technical SEO Without the Tech Overload · Part 7 · Social Search · + 3 more

Your system so far:

```
Keyword Universe → Search Intent → Site Architecture → Collections → Products
     → Content Clusters → 30 Content Opportunities
```

You now know *which* pages to build. This Part covers *how to actually build one well* — in a way that's equally clear to a person skimming it and a search engine trying to understand it. Those two goals are almost never in conflict; a page that's genuinely clear to a human is usually exactly what ranks.

SECTION 14

Anatomy of a Search-Optimized Shopify Page

LEARN

There's no secret formula here, and be suspicious of anyone who tells you there is. The real underlying principle is simple to say and takes practice to do well:

> NOTE
> **Make the page's topic, purpose, and value unmistakably clear — without ever making it sound like it was written for a search engine instead of a person.**

Everything below is one page, walked top to bottom, in the order a real visitor experiences it.

1. URL

What it communicates: the page's topic, at a glance, before anyone even clicks. `/products/soy-wax-candle-sandalwood-8oz` tells both a person and Google what's on the other end. `/products/product-14829` tells nobody anything.

What clean looks like: short, readable, hyphens between words (not underscores or spaces), matching the page title in plain language.

> DON'T DO THIS
> Don't casually rename the URL of a page that's already live and getting traffic just to "clean it up." Changing a URL breaks the old link — anyone who bookmarked it, anywhere it's linked from elsewhere on the web, and any ranking history tied to that exact address. Shopify will offer to set up a redirect (old URL → new URL) when you change one; if you're editing an established page's URL, always accept that redirect. For a brand-new page that's never been published, there's nothing to protect — clean it up freely.

2. Title Tag (the blue link in search results)

What it is: the clickable headline Google shows in search results — set under each page's "Search engine listing" panel (you did this already for your product in Section 8). It's a different field from the

H1 you'll write next; they often say something similar, but they're not the same thing and don't have to be worded identically.

Where else it appears: the browser tab, and often as the default text if someone shares the page link.

How to make it useful: lead with what the page is actually about, in the words a real customer would use — not a clever brand tagline, not a wall of stacked keywords.

Weaker	Soy Candles | Soy Candle | Best Soy Candles | Buy Soy Candles
Better	Non-Toxic Soy Candles for a Cleaner Burn | Juniper Lane

The "weaker" version isn't just unpleasant to read — repeating the same keyword in slightly different forms like this is a pattern search engines are specifically good at recognizing as low-quality, and it doesn't help you rank better than saying it once, clearly.

A practical note on length: Google doesn't cut off titles at an exact character count — it truncates based on pixel width (roughly 580–600 pixels on desktop, which works out to somewhere around 50–60 characters for most fonts, more on mobile). Don't treat any character number as a hard rule; treat it as "keep the important part near the front, because the tail end may get cut." **Google will also sometimes display a different title than the one you wrote** — usually when your title is too long, stuffed with repeated keywords, generic ("Home \| Untitled"), or when Google decides your H1 or page content is a clearer match for what the searcher typed. Writing a clear, honest, non-stuffed title is the best way to reduce how often that happens — not a guarantee it never will.

3. Meta Description

What it does: the 1–2 line summary under your title in search results. Its job is to earn the click, not to rank the page.

What it does NOT do: directly affect your ranking. Google has stated this consistently for over a decade, and it's still true — the meta description carries no ranking weight on its own.

Why it still matters: a clear, specific, honest meta description is often the difference between someone clicking your result or a competitor's for the exact same search position. And **Google frequently rewrites it anyway** — pulling a more relevant snippet of on-page text if it thinks that serves the searcher better than what you wrote. Write a genuinely good one regardless; think of it as your best attempt at the ad copy for a click you don't pay for, not a technical SEO field with rules to game.

4. H1 (the visible page heading)

Its job: confirm, in plain sight, the moment someone lands on the page, that they're in the right place. This is what a human actually sees and reads first — separate from the title tag, which lives in the browser tab and search results.

Awkward	Best Non Toxic Soy Candles Buy Online Cheap

Natural	Non-Toxic Soy Candles

The natural version says the same thing without sounding like it's talking to a search engine. That's the test for every element on this page: read it out loud — does it sound like something a person would actually say?

5. Opening Copy

Its job: answer, in the first sentence or two, "what is this page about, and am I in the right place?" — before a visitor has to scroll to find out. For a commercial page, connect this directly to what they can do next: browse, compare, buy.

6. Product / Collection Information

This is where real, specific information about what you're selling naturally reinforces what the page is about — without needing to "insert keywords." A genuinely thorough, accurate product or collection description that answers real buyer questions (Section 8's seven questions) will naturally use the language real customers search for, because that's the same language customers use to ask about it.

7. Supporting Headings (H2s and beyond)

Their job: organize the information a customer actually needs into scannable sections — not serve as a checklist of places to wedge in another keyword. Ask "what does someone reading this still need to know at this point?" not "where can I fit my keyword again?" A good H2 makes a reader more likely to keep reading; a keyword-stuffed one makes them leave.

8. Images

- Use real, specific, useful imagery — not generic stock photos that could belong to any store.
- Write alt text that accurately describes what's in the image (Section 8 covered exactly where to add this) — a sentence a person would say if describing the photo to someone who can't see it, not a list of keywords.
- Alt text also serves accessibility — screen readers read it aloud for visually impaired visitors, which is reason enough on its own, separate from any SEO benefit.
- On Shopify, most image delivery performance is handled for you: Shopify's CDN automatically serves modern, smaller image formats to browsers that support them, and most themes support lazy loading (images below the fold load only as a visitor scrolls to them) out of the box. You still control image quality going in — reasonably sized, reasonably compressed images upload faster and display faster than unnecessarily massive files, even with Shopify's delivery optimization underneath them.

9. FAQs / Customer Questions

Genuinely useful for customer clarity, addressing objections, and giving a complete picture of the product or category — including to AI systems trying to summarize or understand your page (more on this in Part 8). **Not** a way to earn Google's FAQ rich result in search — Google discontinued that feature in 2026 (you saw this note in Section 8; it applies here too). Include FAQs because they make the page better, not because of a search-result feature that no longer exists.

10. Internal Links

Every page should link somewhere useful — a related collection, a supporting article, a related product. This is important enough to get its own full treatment next in Section 15; for now, just know it belongs here, contextually, in the flow of the copy — not bolted on as an afterthought at the bottom.

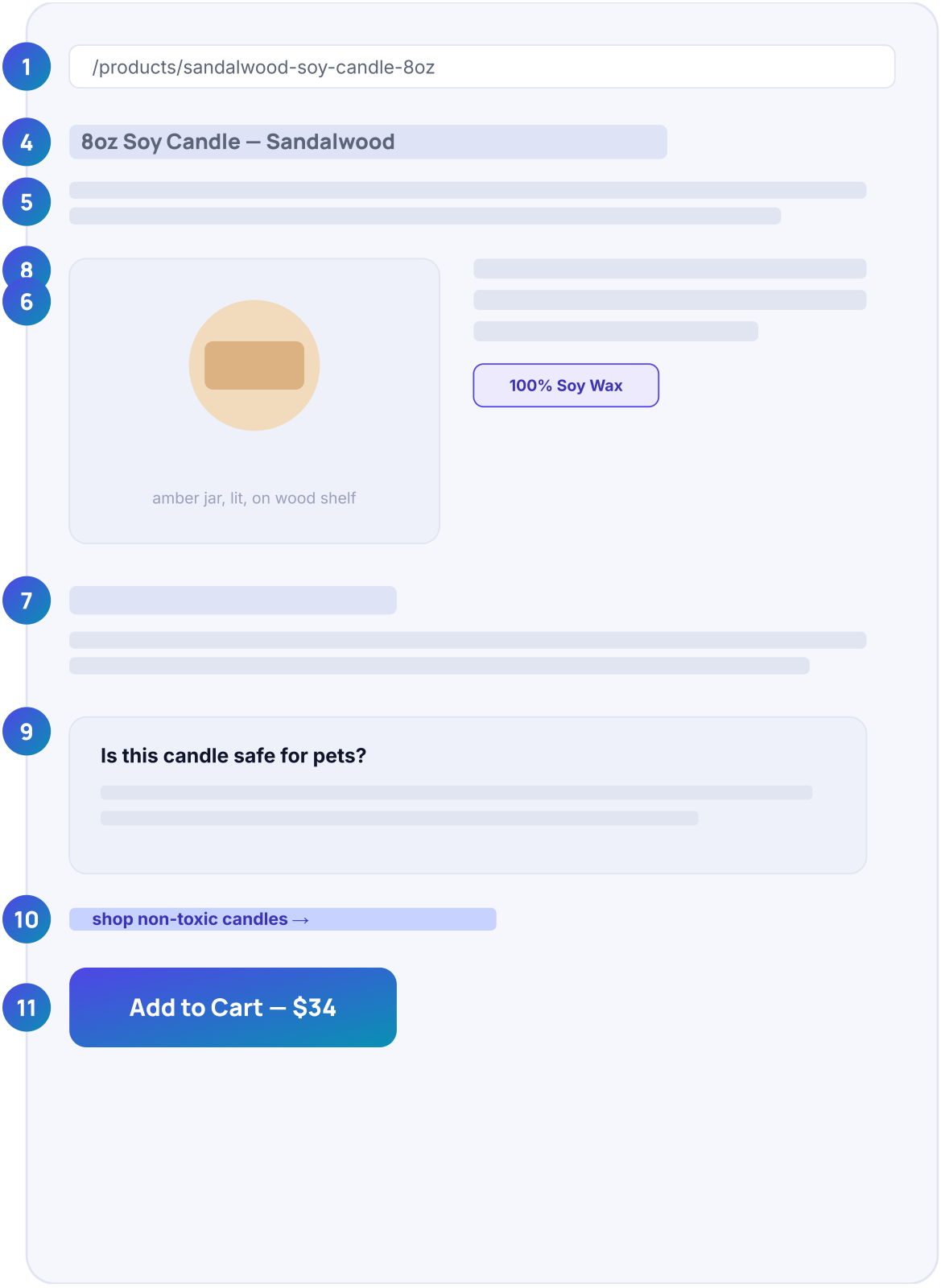
11. Call to Action

Ranking isn't the goal — a visitor taking a next step is. Every page needs an obvious one:

PAGE TYPE	NATURAL NEXT ACTION
Product page	Choose an option, add to cart
Collection page	Browse products, filter/narrow down
Informational article	View the relevant collection, compare options, read a related article
Comparison/buying-guide article	Shop the recommended collection or product

SECTION 14 · SIGNATURE ASSET

Anatomy of a Search-Optimized Shopify Page



Numbered 1–11 in reading order: URL · title tag/search preview · meta description · H1 · opening copy · product info · supporting headings · image + alt text · FAQ · internal links · CTA.

PAGE 2 OF 2

The Search Result Preview — Zoomed

Elements 2 and 3 aren't visible on the live page itself — they only exist in the search result. Here's what they actually look like.

juniperlanecandle.com › products › sandalwood

8oz Soy Candle – Sandalwood, Amber Jar 2 · TITLE TAG

Hand-poured soy candle, 45+ hr burn, non-toxic — safe around pets. 3 · META DESCRIPTION

All 11, At a Glance

1. **URL**
   What the page is about, at a glance
2. **Title tag**
   The clickable headline in results
3. **Meta description**
   Earns the click, not the ranking
4. **H1**
   Confirms "you're in the right place"
5. **Opening copy**
   What is this, am I in the right place?
6. **Product info**
   Reinforces topic without stuffing
7. **Supporting headings**
   Organize, don't insert keywords
8. **Image + alt text**
   Describe what's actually shown
9. **FAQ**
   Clarity, not a rich-result play
10. **Internal links**
    In context, not bolted on
11. **CTA**
    The obvious next action

DO — Your Page-Optimization Workflow

Use this sequence every time you build or improve a page. It's the same process whether it's your fifth product or your fiftieth.

✎ Checklist — The Page-Optimization Workflow

- [ ] 1. Identify the page's primary purpose (sell a product, sell a category, answer a question, help someone decide)
- [ ] 2. Identify the primary search intent it serves (Section 5)
- [ ] 3. Confirm the main topic/keyword cluster it targets (Sections 4, 7, 11)
- [ ] 4. Write a clear title tag
- [ ] 5. Write the H1
- [ ] 6. Write the opening copy — what is this, am I in the right place?
- [ ] 7. Add the real information a shopper actually needs
- [ ] 8. Structure supporting sections around what they still need to know
- [ ] 9. Add and optimize images, with real alt text
- [ ] 10. Add relevant internal links, in context
- [ ] 11. Write the meta description
- [ ] 12. Confirm the CTA / next action is obvious
- [ ] 13. Read the whole page out loud, as a human
- [ ] 14. Check: does anything feel stuffed, repetitive, or like it was written for a robot? If so, rewrite it.

✨ ASK AI

Once you have a full page draft, this is a genuinely useful review pass:

> *Here's a draft of my [product/collection/article] page: [paste your actual draft]. Read it as a real shopper would. Flag any sentences that feel unnaturally repetitive, keyword-stuffed, or like they were written for a search engine instead of a person — and suggest a more natural rewrite for each one.*

This works on a page you've already written — it's a polish pass, not a starting point. Don't ask AI to write the whole page from scratch and publish it unedited; it doesn't know your product the way you do, and it will happily write something generic-sounding that technically covers the topic without actually being good.

CHECK YOUR WORK

Hand the finished page to someone who's never seen your product — a friend, a partner, anyone. Ask them: "What is this, and what am I supposed to do next?" If they can answer both instantly, the page is doing its job.

SECTION 15

Internal Linking

LEARN

You've now built collections, products, and content clusters. Internal linking is how you connect them into one navigable system — for shoppers finding their way around, and for search engines figuring out which pages matter and how they relate.

Every internal link should do at least one of these jobs:

PURPOSE	WHAT IT DOES
Discovery	Helps search engines (and visitors) find a page they might not have reached otherwise
Context	Signals how two pages/topics relate to each other
Navigation	Helps a shopper continue their journey without hitting a dead end
Commercial path	Gives informational traffic a clear route to a relevant product or collection

There's no universal rule like "every article needs exactly 3 internal links." The right number is whatever genuinely serves the reader in that specific piece of content — sometimes one well-placed link matters more than five scattered ones.

The core relationships to build:

- **Blog → Collection** — a supporting article links to the commercial page it exists to support (this is the link you sketched conceptually back in Section 11–12 — now you're actually building it).
- **Product → Collection** — every product links back to at least one collection it belongs to.
- **Collection → Related Collection** — genuinely related categories link to each other (e.g., "Non-Toxic Candles" ↔ "Candles for Sensitive Homes"), so a shopper who's close but not quite in the right category has somewhere useful to go.
- **Blog → Related Blog** — articles that share a topic link to each other where it's genuinely useful to the reader, not just because they exist.
- **Guide → Product**, where genuinely useful — a buying guide or comparison article can link directly to a specific recommended product, not just its collection.

Anchor text (the clickable words themselves) should describe where the link goes, in natural language:

Bad	“click here”
Also bad	“best non toxic soy candles buy soy candles online” (a keyword phrase pretending to be a sentence)
Better	“shop our non-toxic candle collection”

Natural, varied anchor text reads better for humans and avoids the same over-stuffed pattern that hurts title tags and H1s. If every link on your site uses the exact same rigid phrase, that’s a sign it’s being written for a search engine, not a reader.

Orphan pages

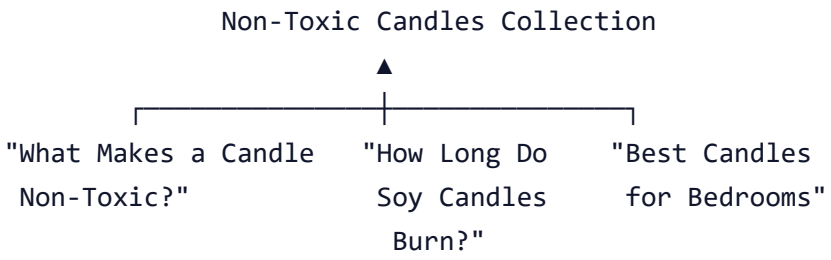
An **orphan page** is a page that exists on your store but has no real internal path leading to it — no navigation menu link, no link from a collection or article, nothing a visitor could click through to find it. It might still technically be reachable by direct URL, but functionally, nobody (person or search engine) can discover it by browsing your site.

Orphan pages are a problem because a page nobody can find is a page doing no work — all the effort you put into optimizing it (Sections 8, 10, and 13) is wasted if nothing points to it.

A simple way to spot them right now: open your store’s navigation menu and click through it like a first-time visitor. For every important collection, product, and article you’ve built or planned in this workbook, can you actually get there by clicking, without already knowing the URL? Anything you can’t reach that way is effectively orphaned. (A full technical crawl that catches every orphan page automatically is a Part 6 topic — Section 18 — this is the fast manual version you can do today.)

SEE — connecting a content cluster with real links

Back in Section 11, you saw this cluster as a concept:



Here’s the same cluster with the actual links now in place:

- “What Makes a Candle Non-Toxic?” **links to** the Non-Toxic Candles collection, with anchor text like *“shop our full non-toxic candle collection.”*
- “How Long Do Soy Candles Burn?” **links to** the same collection, and **also links sideways** to “What Makes a Candle Non-Toxic?” where it naturally comes up in the text.
- The Non-Toxic Candles collection page itself **links down** to all three articles, likely in a “Learn More” or “Related Reading” section near the bottom.
- Each product inside that collection **links back up** to the collection it belongs to (built in Section 8).

That’s the cluster concept from Part 4, no longer a diagram — an actual connected path a visitor (or Google) can follow all the way from a question to a purchase.

DO

✎ Worksheet — My Internal Linking Plan

Pull from everything you've built: your Site Architecture (Section 6), Collection Map (Section 7), optimized product (Section 8), and Content Clusters (Section 12).

Worked example — Juniper Lane:

SOURCE PAGE	DESTINATION PAGE	WHY THIS LINK HELPS	SUGGESTED ANCHOR/CONTEXT	ADDED?
"How Long Do Soy Candles Burn?" (article)	Non-Toxic Candles collection	Commercial path — reader learning about burn time is close to shopping	"browse our non-toxic candle collection"	☐
Sandalwood Soy Candle (product)	Non-Toxic Candles collection	Navigation — lets shopper explore beyond this one product	"see more non-toxic candles"	☐
Non-Toxic Candles collection	"What Makes a Candle Non-Toxic?" (article)	Context — answers the "why" behind the collection for an unsure shopper	"learn what makes a candle non-toxic"	☐

Your plan:

SOURCE PAGE	DESTINATION PAGE	WHY THIS LINK HELPS	SUGGESTED ANCHOR/CONTEXT	ADDED?
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐

Aim to cover every commercial page from your Collection Map and every article from your Content Clusters at least once as either a source or a destination. A page that never appears in either column is a candidate orphan — go back and give it a home.

✨ **ASK AI**

This works best once you have a real list of your actual pages — not as a cold "what should I link to" question:

> *Here is a list of my actual store pages: [list your real collections, products, and planned/published articles, with a one-line description of each]. Suggest internal linking opportunities between them — which pages should link to which, why, and a natural anchor text suggestion for each. Flag any pages on my list that don't seem to be receiving any links from the others.*

The output is only as good as the page list you provide — a vague or incomplete list produces vague, unreliable suggestions.

CHECK YOUR WORK

Scan your finished plan for any destination that never appears as a source elsewhere, and any page you've built that never appears as a destination at all — those are your orphan risks. Fix the highest-priority ones (your top collections and highest-priority content, from Sections 7 and 11) first.

PART 6

06

TECHNICAL SEO WITHOUT THE TECH OVERLOAD

✦ YOUR SYSTEM SO FAR

- Part 0 · Your Starting Point
- Part 1 · Your Organic Traffic Foundation
- Part 2 · Find What People Are Searching For
- Part 3 · Turn Keywords Into a Shopify Store
- Part 4 · Content That Actually Supports Sales
- Part 5 · On-Page SEO

YOU ARE HERE

Part 6 — Technical SEO Without the Tech Overload

Technical Health Check

Part 7 · Social Search

Part 8 · AI Search

+ 2 more

Your system so far:

```
Keyword Universe → Search Intent → Site Architecture → Collections → Products
     → Content Clusters → 30 Content Opportunities → On-Page Optimization → Internal Links
```

You've built the strategy and the pages. This Part answers a quieter, more anxious question a lot of store owners carry around without saying out loud: *"Can Google actually see any of this?"* By the end, you'll know how to check — and, just as importantly, you'll know which parts of that question Shopify already answered for you before you ever asked it.

You're not becoming a technical SEO consultant in this Part. You're becoming someone who can competently check their own homework.

SECTION 16

Is Google Actually Finding Your Store?

LEARN

Four steps happen between "you publish a page" and "someone finds it on Google," and beginners usually collapse all four into one word ("SEO"), which makes troubleshooting feel impossible. Pull them apart:

STEP	IN PLAIN ENGLISH
Discover	Google learns a URL exists at all (usually via your sitemap, or a link from somewhere else)
Crawl	Google visits the page and reads it
Index	Google decides whether to store it as a candidate to show in search results
Rank	Google decides *if and where* it might appear for a specific search

Two things beginners get backwards constantly — read these twice:

> NOTE
>
> Being **indexed** does not mean you're guaranteed to **rank** well for anything. Indexing just means the page is in Google's library. Ranking is a separate, ongoing competition against every other page trying to answer the same search. **Not ranking** for a term does not automatically mean you have an **indexing problem**. Most of the time, a page that's indexed but not ranking simply hasn't earned a place yet — through content quality, relevance, competition, or time (Section 23 covers this honestly). Jumping straight to "something's technically broken" is the most common false alarm in beginner SEO.

Where Shopify already has your back

A lot of technical SEO panic is unnecessary, because Shopify handles the plumbing for most of it by default. Here's the honest breakdown:

CONCEPT	SHOPIFY GENERALLY HANDLES THIS FOR YOU	YOU SHOULD PERIODICALLY CHECK	MAY NEED TECHNICAL HELP IF WRONG
XML sitemap	✅ Auto-generated and auto-updated	Confirm it's submitted in Search Console (Section 17)	Rare
robots.txt	✅ Sensible default provided	Only if you suspect something's blocked (Section 18)	If you need custom rules
Canonical tags	✅ Set automatically	Spot-check an important page occasionally	If duplicates persist across many pages
HTTPS/security	✅ Free SSL on every store	Confirm the padlock shows on your live domain	If a custom-domain DNS issue breaks it
noindex on standalone Pages	You control this via a simple toggle	Confirm important pages aren't accidentally hidden	Rarely
noindex on products/collections	Requires a small theme code edit if needed	Only if you have a specific reason to hide one	If you're not comfortable in theme code
Redirects on URL changes	You control this — Shopify won't do it automatically	Every time you change an established URL	Rare

Keep this table in mind through the rest of this section — most rows are already checked "handled" before you do anything.

The sitemap

What it is: a file listing your important URLs, so Google can discover them efficiently instead of having to stumble onto every page by chance.

What Shopify does: generates and maintains it automatically at `yourdomain.com/sitemap.xml` — you never build this by hand. Behind that one file, Shopify actually organizes your pages into several sub-sitemaps (products, collections, pages, blog posts), especially once your catalog is large — Shopify splits a sub-sitemap automatically once it exceeds 5,000 URLs. You don't need to manage that split; Shopify's sitemap.xml links to all of them automatically.

How to view it: visit `yourdomain.com/sitemap.xml` in a browser right now — you'll see XML, not a pretty page, but you'll see it's there and populated.

How it connects forward: you'll submit this exact URL to Google Search Console in Section 17 — that's the main action item here, and it's the only one.

DO THIS NOW

Open a new tab and visit `[your domain]/sitemap.xml`. Confirm it loads and lists real URLs. That's the whole check.

robots.txt

What it does: tells search engine crawlers which parts of your site they're allowed to visit — a set of instructions, not a lock.

What Shopify provides by default: a sensible, working robots.txt file automatically, at `yourdomain.com/robots.txt`, that already blocks things that shouldn't be crawled (like cart and checkout URLs) without you doing anything.

> LEAVE THIS ALONE
>
> **DON'T TOUCH THIS UNLESS YOU HAVE A SPECIFIC REASON.** Customizing robots.txt requires editing theme code, and Shopify itself flags this as an unsupported customization — meaning if something goes wrong, Shopify Support won't be able to help you fix it. Getting it wrong can accidentally block Google from crawling your entire store. For the overwhelming majority of small stores, the default is correct and there is no reason to open this file at all. If you ever have a genuine, specific reason to customize it (blocking a particular bot, adding a non-standard sitemap reference), that's a good moment for the "Research Before Changing" or "Consider Technical Help" buckets later in Section 18 — not a Tuesday-afternoon DIY edit.

Canonical URLs

What it means, with an analogy: imagine your product is technically reachable through more than one door — say, both `/products/sandalwood-candle` and `/collections/non-toxic/products/sandalwood-candle`. Both doors lead to the same room. A canonical tag is a sign on the door that says "this is the official address — if you saw another way in, treat this one as the real one." It tells Google which version to treat as primary, so your ranking strength consolidates onto one URL instead of splitting across several.

Why duplicates happen: mostly from Shopify's own collection-scoped product URLs (exactly the example above) — this is normal store behavior, not a mistake you made.

What Shopify does: sets canonical tags automatically on your product and collection pages, generally pointing to the clean `/products/` version.

What normal looks like: you don't notice this at all, because it's working. *What might indicate a problem:* the same exact page content ranking under two completely different, unrelated-looking URLs over an extended period — genuinely rare, and hard to diagnose without a technical tool. If you suspect it, that's a "Consider Technical Help" situation (Section 18), not something to self-diagnose by staring at URLs.

AVOID SCARE LANGUAGE

Having duplicate-looking URLs on Shopify does not create a “Google penalty.” There’s no punishment here — just a question of which version search engines should treat as the main one, which Shopify is already answering for you in almost every normal case.

Noindex

What it means: a specific instruction telling search engines "don't include this exact page in search results." Different from a page simply not ranking — noindex is a deliberate exclusion, either intentional (you don't want your returns policy showing up in search) or accidental (a setting got toggled without realizing what it does).

Checking an important page yourself: for a standalone Page (like an About or FAQ page), go to **Online Store → Pages → [the page] → Visibility**, and confirm "Hide page from search engines" is *unchecked* for anything you actually want found. For products and collections, there's no equivalent one-click toggle in the standard admin — hiding one from search requires a small code snippet in your theme, which makes accidental noindexing of a *product* rarer than accidentally hiding a standalone Page.

What might indicate a problem: an important page that mysteriously isn't showing up anywhere in Google, even for a `site:yourdomain.com "exact page title"` search (Part 0's Question 3 check, applied to one specific page). Section 17's URL Inspection tool gives you a definitive answer.

Redirects

You saw this warning already in Section 14: don't casually change an established URL. Here's the mechanism that protects you when you do need to.

The concept: old URL → redirect → new URL. Anyone (or any search engine) that still has the old address gets automatically sent to the new one instead of hitting a broken page.

Where to set one up: in your Shopify admin, look for **URL Redirects** (currently under Content → Menus → View URL Redirects, though Shopify's admin navigation labels shift occasionally — if you can't find it where described, search "redirect" in your admin's search bar). Enter the old path in "Redirect from" and the new path in "Redirect to," then save. It takes effect immediately.

When you need this: any time you change a product, collection, or page URL that's already live and might be linked to, bookmarked, or indexed. Shopify will often prompt you to create this redirect automatically right when you change a URL — accept it.

> **CHECK YOUR WORK**

Go back to the Shopify-handles-this table at the top of this section. For each row marked "You should periodically check," do that check right now, on one important page. Everything else, leave alone — that's not avoidance, that's correctly trusting a default that's already working.


Discover
Crawl
Index
Rank" pipeline diagram, simple lef

SECTION 17

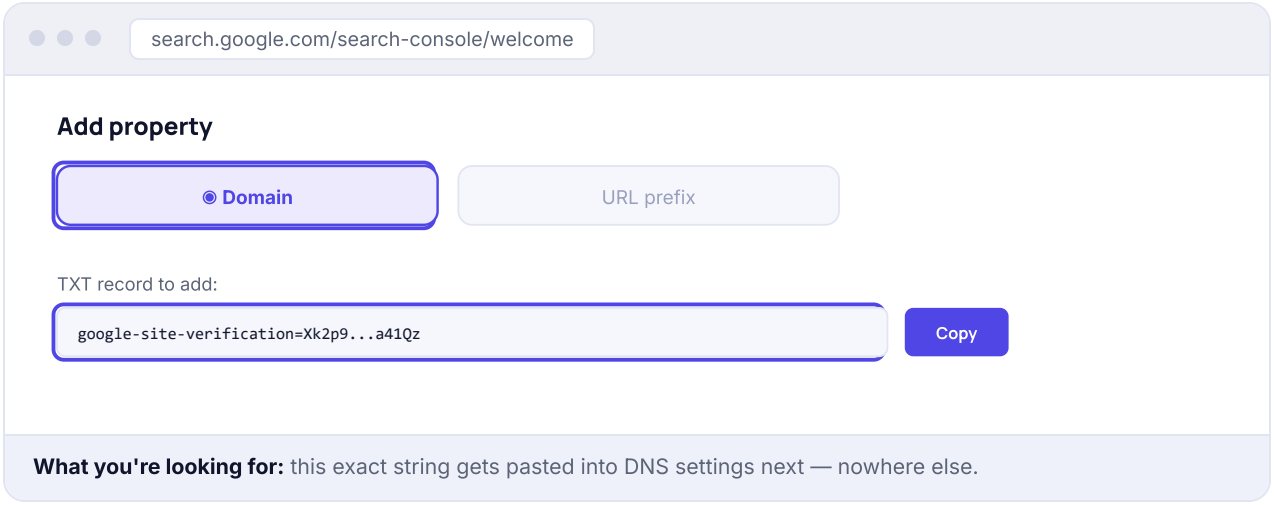
Set Up Google Search Console

LEARN

If you did Part 0's health check, you already know whether this exists for your store. This section is the full walkthrough — expect about 15–20 minutes, most of which is just waiting on DNS.

Setup

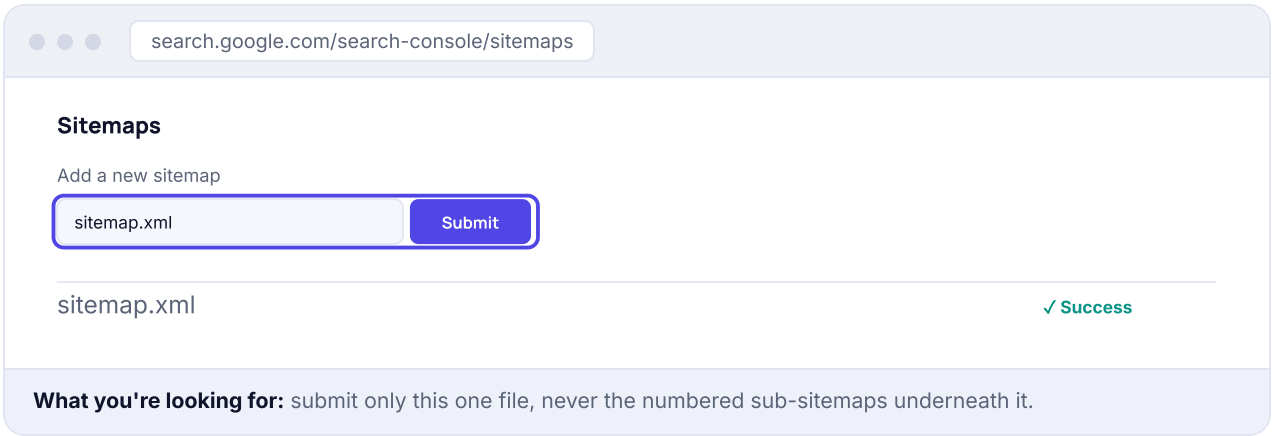
1. Go to search.google.com/search-console and click **Add property**.
2. Choose the **Domain** option (not "URL prefix") — this covers your whole domain, including `www` and non-`www` and both `http`/`https` versions, in one property, which is the cleaner choice for most stores.
3. Google gives you a **TXT record** to add. Where you add it depends on where your domain lives:
    - **Domain purchased through Shopify:** go to **Settings** → **Domains** → **[your domain]** → **DNS settings** in your Shopify admin, and add the TXT record there directly — no third-party account needed.
    - **Domain purchased elsewhere, pointed at Shopify:** log into that registrar (GoDaddy, Namecheap, Google Domains, etc. — wherever you actually bought the domain, not Shopify) and add the TXT record in its DNS settings.
4. Return to Search Console and click **Verify**. DNS changes can take anywhere from a few minutes up to 48 hours to fully take effect — if verification fails immediately, wait and try again before assuming something's wrong.
5. Once verified, go to **Sitemaps** in the left menu, and submit exactly `sitemap.xml` — nothing more specific. **Do not submit individual sub-sitemaps** (like `sitemap_products_1.xml`) even though you now know they exist — submitting them separately can cause duplicate processing and actually slow down how Google works through your site. One sitemap.xml submission covers everything underneath it.
6. Data does not appear instantly. Expect a genuinely blank-looking Performance report for the first several days to a couple of weeks on a new or newly-verified property — this is completely normal, not a sign of a problem.



What you're looking for: this exact string gets pasted into DNS settings next — nowhere else.



What you're looking for: the record-type dropdown and value field — this is the in-Shopify path for domains bought through Shopify, no external registrar login needed.



What you're looking for: submit only this one file, never the numbered sub-sitemaps underneath it.

What do I actually look at?

Once data starts populating, the Performance report is where you'll spend most of your time. Here's what each number is actually answering — this table is worth bookmarking:

METRIC	WHAT IT TELLS YOU	WHAT IT DOESN'T TELL YOU	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Impressions	How often your pages appeared anywhere in search results, for any query	Whether anyone actually clicked, or where exactly you appeared	A rising trend over weeks/months — one day's number means almost nothing
Clicks	How many people actually chose your result	Why they didn't click if impressions are high but clicks are low (that's usually a title/snippet problem — Section 14)	Growth alongside impressions, not just impressions alone
CTR (click-through rate)	What share of impressions turned into a click	Whether your ranking position is good or bad on its own	A CTR that's unusually low for your average position — a signal your title/description isn't earning the click it should
Average position	Roughly where you tend to appear for a query, averaged over the date range	Your exact rank on any single search (positions shift constantly, by searcher, location, and device)	Gradual movement over months, not daily swings
Queries	What people actually searched to find you	Whether that search converted to a sale	Real, unexpected phrases — often better keyword research than any tool, because it's not a guess, it's what actually happened
Pages	Which of your pages are earning any search visibility at all	Why a specific page isn't showing here (could be too new, too weak, or genuinely not indexed)	Pages from your Collection Map or Content Clusters that are *absent* here entirely — worth investigating

GOOD TO KNOW

SEARCH CONSOLE IS NOT A PERFECT RANK TRACKER. Position numbers are averaged, delayed by a few days, and can bounce around from personalization, location, and device differences you can't see. Checking it daily and reacting to every wiggle is a fast way to make yourself anxious over noise. Check weekly or monthly, and look for a *trend*, not a headline number.

✨ **ASK AI**

Once you have a few weeks of real Performance data, Search Console lets you export it (Export → CSV or Google Sheets, top right of the report). A genuinely useful way to use AI here:

> *Here's my Google Search Console query export for the past [time period]: [paste the actual data]. Group these queries into themes, flag any surprising or unexpected queries I'm ranking for that I hadn't targeted intentionally, and note any queries with high impressions but low clicks — those usually mean the page is showing up but the title or snippet isn't earning the click.*

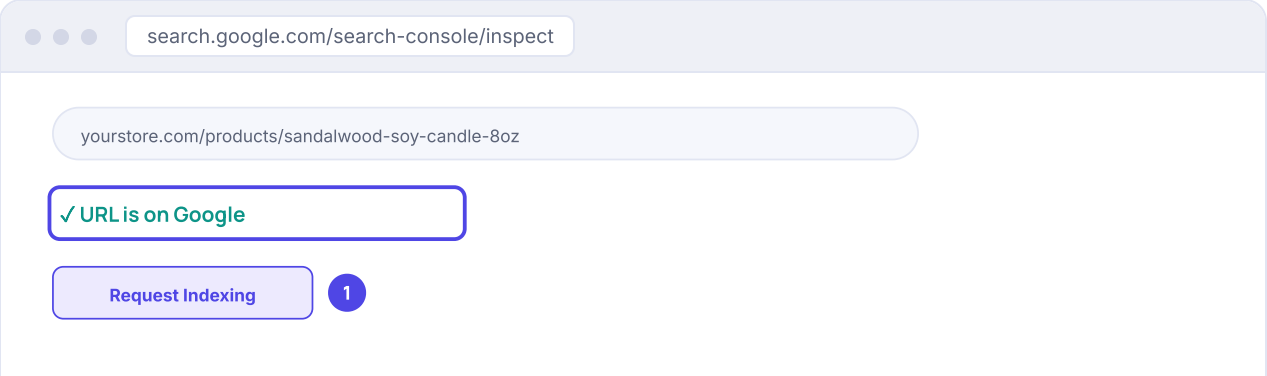
This works only on your real exported data — never ask AI to guess at what your Search Console numbers "probably" look like, and don't treat a data-free answer as if it were an actual report.

Indexing checks

At the top of Search Console is a search bar — paste any URL from your own site into it to run **URL Inspection**. This tells you, for that specific page:

- Whether it's currently indexed
- If not, roughly why (not yet crawled, blocked, a canonical pointing elsewhere, etc.)
- A **"Request Indexing"** button

What "Request Indexing" actually does: it asks Google to prioritize crawling that specific URL sooner rather than waiting for its normal schedule. **It is not a ranking button.** Requesting indexing gets a page looked at faster — it does nothing to make Google decide the page deserves to rank well once it's there. Use it after you've published or significantly updated an important page, not as a repeated ritual you perform hoping it'll boost rankings.



What you're looking for: this is how you get a definitive yes/no for one specific page, and where the (non-magic) Request Indexing button lives.

CHECK YOUR WORK

Run URL Inspection on your Section 8 optimized product and your Section 7 priority collection. Both should come back indexed within a reasonable window after publishing (allow a few days to a

couple of weeks on a newer store). If either comes back “not indexed” well after that window, that’s your first genuinely actionable technical finding — worth a closer look using Section 18’s framework.

SECTION 18

Technical Health Check

LEARN

This is not a 47-point audit designed to make you anxious about every yellow warning a tool throws at you. It's a short, prioritized checkup: a handful of things worth fixing now, a handful worth keeping an eye on, and a longer list you can stop worrying about entirely.

Tools you'll actually use — all free:

TOOL	WHAT IT CHECKS	GET IT AT
Google Search Console	Indexing, performance, sitemap status	search.google.com/search-console (Section 17)
PageSpeed Insights	Page speed, Core Web Vitals (lab + real-world data)	pagespeed.web.dev
Chrome Lighthouse	Same engine as PageSpeed Insights, built into Chrome's DevTools (right-click a page → Inspect → Lighthouse tab)	Already in your browser
Rich Results Test	Whether your structured data is valid and what rich results it's eligible for	search.google.com/test/rich-results
Schema Markup Validator	Broader schema.org validation, beyond just Google-specific features	validator.schema.org
Bing Webmaster Tools	A second search engine's view of your indexing (worth a quick setup — it can often import your Search Console data)	bing.com/webmasters

You don't need a paid subscription to run a legitimate technical check on a small Shopify store. If a tool tries to sell you a monthly plan before showing you basic results, that's a sign to look elsewhere first.

Page speed and Core Web Vitals, without the rabbit hole

Page speed affects both how Google evaluates the page experience and, just as importantly, whether a real visitor sticks around long enough to buy anything. Core Web Vitals are Google's specific metrics for measuring that experience — loading speed, visual stability, and responsiveness, broadly.

Run PageSpeed Insights on your homepage and your Section 8 product page. You'll see two kinds of data:

- **Lab data** — a one-time simulated test, useful for spotting specific problems (like an oversized image), but not what real visitors actually experienced.
- **Field data** — real measurements from actual visitors over the past 28 days (when your store has enough traffic to generate it). This is closer to what genuinely matters, but a new or low-traffic store often won't have enough field data yet — that's normal, not a failure.

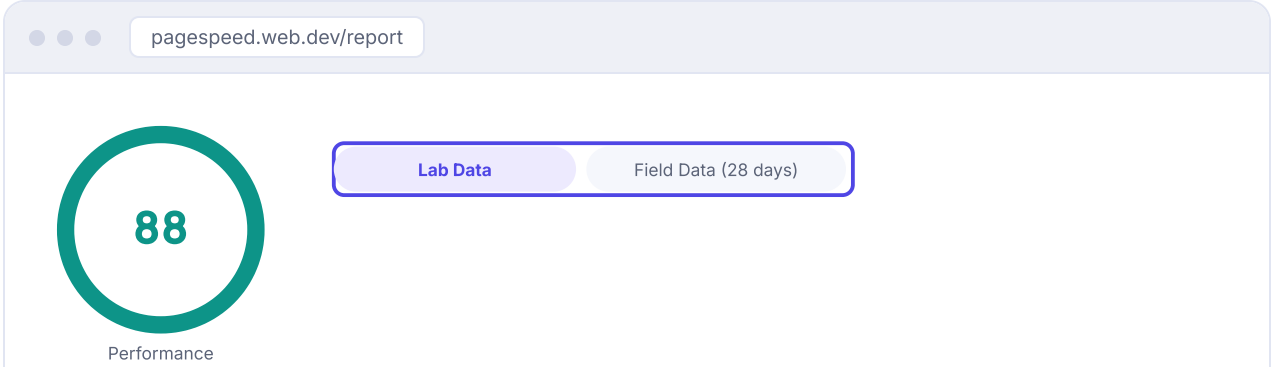
> **MYTH TO IGNORE**
>
> You do not need a perfect 100 PageSpeed score to rank well, and chasing one is a poor use of a small store owner's time. A reasonable, unremarkable score with no glaring red flags is entirely sufficient. Treat a very low score (consistently in the red) as worth investigating; treat "89 instead of 100" as not worth another minute of your attention.

Structured data — a quick, honest check

Structured data (also called schema) is extra, machine-readable information embedded in your page that helps search engines (and increasingly, AI systems) understand exactly what they're looking at — this product's price, availability, and so on. Shopify themes generate basic product structured data automatically; you generally don't need to build this from scratch.

Run your Section 8 product page through the **Rich Results Test**. It'll show you what's currently detected. If something looks broken or missing, that's worth noting — but resist the urge to have an AI tool generate custom schema code for you to paste into your theme "to be safe." Structured data that doesn't accurately match what's actually on the page can cause more problems than having none at all, and pasted-in code you don't understand is exactly the kind of thing that's hard to debug later. If your theme's default output looks reasonable and matches your actual product information, that's enough for a small store.

> **NOTE**
>
> Reminder from Section 8: FAQ schema will not earn you Google's FAQ rich result — that feature was discontinued in 2026. Check structured data for accuracy and completeness, not because a specific rich-result payoff is riding on it.



What you're looking for: these are two different measurements, not one score — check both before drawing a conclusion.



What you're looking for: this confirms what Google can currently read from the page's structured data, without needing to view raw code.

DO

✎ Worksheet — My Shopify Technical SEO Check

🔴 RED — FIX OR INVESTIGATE NOW

- [ ] Storefront is password protected (Part 0, Question 1)
- [ ] An important page (priority product/collection) is confirmed *not indexed* after a reasonable waiting period (Section 17)
- [ ] Store navigation has an obviously broken/dead link on a primary menu
- [ ] PageSpeed Insights shows a consistently poor (red-range) score on your homepage or a priority product page
- [ ] Your live domain doesn't show a secure padlock / HTTPS in the browser

🟡 YELLOW — REVIEW WHEN YOU HAVE TIME

- [ ] A handful of product images are unusually large/unoptimized (check file sizes before upload going forward)
- [ ] A few broken internal links found while building your Section 15 linking plan
- [ ] Core Web Vitals show room for improvement, but not in the red
- [ ] Rich Results Test shows a warning (not an error) on structured data
- [ ] You're unsure whether a specific page's canonical is behaving correctly

🟢 GREEN — SHOPIFY HANDLES THIS; DON'T SPEND TIME HERE

- [ ] Sitemap generation and maintenance
- [ ] Default robots.txt behavior
- [ ] Canonical tags on standard product/collection pages
- [ ] Basic HTTPS/SSL provisioning
- [ ] Basic product structured data output from your theme

Work the Red items first, always. Yellow items are worth a monthly glance, not urgent attention. Green items are listed here specifically so you can stop checking them — that's the point of the category.

"Can I fix this myself?"

BUCKET	EXAMPLES	WHAT TO DO
Probably DIY	Submit sitemap, run URL Inspection, fix one broken internal link, edit alt text, change an obvious page title, set up a redirect	Just do it — these are low-risk, in-admin tasks covered directly in this workbook

BUCKET	EXAMPLES	WHAT TO DO
Research before changing	Canonical behavior that looks wrong, considering a robots.txt edit, structured data that seems broken, a redirect chain (a URL that redirects to another redirect)	Read Shopify's own current help documentation on the specific issue before touching anything, or ask in the Shopify Community forum with your specific symptom
Consider technical help	Indexing problems across many pages at once, a slow theme that PageSpeed Insights can't explain from the obvious causes, structured data conflicts across templates, canonical issues appearing site-wide	This is genuinely a "bring in help" situation — a freelance Shopify developer, or a deeper professional audit — rather than something to DIY your way through by trial and error

A store-wide, systemic pattern across many pages — rather than one specific page with one specific symptom — is usually the signal that you've crossed from "DIY checklist" into "worth paying for expert eyes." This workbook is built to get you to the point of *recognizing* that pattern and knowing it's real — which is valuable on its own, whether you fix it yourself, hire a freelancer, or bring in a deeper professional audit.

> **CHECK YOUR WORK**

Count your Red items. Zero or one is a healthy small store. Three or more Red items clustered together (especially indexing-related ones) is worth a closer, possibly professional look rather than working through them one at a time in isolation — a cluster of red flags is often one underlying cause, not five separate problems.

PART 7

SOCIAL SEARCH

07

✦ YOUR SYSTEM SO FAR

- ✓ Part 0 · Your Starting Point
- ✓ Part 1 · Your Organic Traffic Foundation
- ✓ Part 2 · Find What People Are Searching For
- ✓ Part 3 · Turn Keywords Into a Shopify Store
- ✓ Part 4 · Content That Actually Supports Sales
- ✓ Part 5 · On-Page SEO
- ✓ Part 6 · Technical SEO Without the Tech Overload

YOU ARE HERE

Part 7 — Social Search

Social Content Plan

Part 8 · AI Search

Part 9 · Measure What Is Working

+ 1 more

Your system so far:

```
Keyword Universe → Search Intent → Site Architecture → Collections → Products
     → Content Clusters → 30 Content Opportunities → On-Page SEO → Internal Links
     → Technical Health Check
```

Everything up to this point has been built around Google. This Part and the next ask a fair question: what about everywhere else people are actually searching?

SECTION 19

TikTok, Instagram, YouTube & Social SEO

LEARN

Here's the honest version of what's happening, without hype in either direction: **it's not that "Google is dead," and it's not that "TikTok is the new Google."** Search behavior has fragmented across more places, and a single customer might move through several of them before ever buying anything:

discover a product on TikTok → search the product category on YouTube for a closer look → check Reddit for real opinions → compare options on Google → ask an AI assistant to summarize the choice → land on your Shopify store directly.

Different platforms serve different moments in that journey. None of them replace the others, and treating "social SEO" as one universal skill — the same way you might think of "Google SEO" — is a mistake, because these platforms don't work the same way as each other, let alone the same way as Google.

How each platform actually works — and what to do about it:

PLATFORM	WHAT PEOPLE COMMONLY SEARCH/DISCOVER THERE	CONTENT FORMAT THAT FITS	WHERE TOPIC SIGNALS CAN APPEAR	WHAT YOU SHOULD ACTUALLY DO
TikTok	Product discovery, "is this worth it," quick how-tos, trends	Short-form video, fast hook	Spoken audio, on-screen text, caption, hashtags (still a real discovery signal here)	Say the topic out loud, show it in on-screen text, and mention it naturally in the caption — TikTok's search genuinely reads and cross-references all three
Instagram	Visual inspiration, aesthetic/lifestyle browsing, "how does this look"	Reels, carousels, single images	Caption text, image alt text, on-screen text — hashtags matter less than they used to	Write real, keyword-natural captions and fill in alt text; don't lean on a pile of hashtags to do the work

PLATFORM	WHAT PEOPLE COMMONLY SEARCH/DISCOVER THERE	CONTENT FORMAT THAT FITS	WHERE TOPIC SIGNALS CAN APPEAR	WHAT YOU SHOULD ACTUALLY DO
YouTube	Longer how-to, comparisons, in-depth reviews, “should I buy this”	Longer video (tutorial, review, comparison)	Title, description, and — importantly — the actual spoken content (via captions/transcript)	Write a clear, specific title and a real description, and make sure captions/transcript are accurate — YouTube (and Google, since YouTube is a Google product) can read what’s actually said in the video, not just the title
Pinterest	Gift ideas, home/lifestyle inspiration, “save for later” planning	Static image or short video pin, strong visual + text overlay	Pin title, description, and the image itself	Genuinely useful for a visually giftable product like candles — worth a light presence if your product photography is strong; less essential if it isn’t a natural fit for your category

Turning your keyword research into social content

Your Keyword Universe (Section 4) already contains the raw material — you just need to translate it, not repeat it. The goal isn’t to say your keyword awkwardly in a caption; it’s to make the *topic* unmistakably clear.

SEE — same underlying customer need, different platform expression:

Google/search theme: **non-toxic candles**

PLATFORM ANGLE	EXAMPLE
TikTok	“3 things I check before buying a candle”
Instagram	A carousel: “What actually makes a candle non-toxic?”
YouTube	“Soy Wax vs. Paraffin: What’s Actually in Your Candle?” (a longer, closer look)
Pinterest	A “Candle Buying Checklist” graphic pin

Same customer question underneath all four. Four genuinely different pieces of content — not the same blog post read aloud on camera.

A note on hashtags — and on social advice generally

Be skeptical of confident-sounding hashtag rules ("use exactly 11 hashtags," "always use 30"). Neither platform publishes its full ranking logic, so a lot of what circulates as "social SEO advice" is really one of three different things, and it's worth knowing which is which:

- **Platform-documented** — something the platform itself has actually stated (rare, and worth trusting most).
- **Reasonable practice** — a pattern many practitioners consistently observe, even without official confirmation (useful, but not gospel).
- **Internet lore** — a rule that gets repeated so often it feels official, without real evidence behind it (the "post at 3pm on Tuesdays" genre of advice).

On hashtags specifically: current reasonable practice on both platforms clusters around a handful (roughly 3–5) of genuinely relevant tags rather than a large pile of them — and on Instagram in particular, hashtags now matter noticeably less than clear captions and alt text for discovery. TikTok still leans on hashtags more directly to help categorize content for its "For You" feed. Neither platform has published an exact formula, so treat any specific hashtag *count* as reasonable practice, not proven fact — and never let hashtag strategy substitute for making a genuinely clear, useful piece of content.

> **DON'T DO THIS**
>
> Don't stack 20–30 loosely-related hashtags hoping one of them sticks. That pattern reads as spammy to viewers and doesn't reflect how either platform's discovery actually works in 2026 — a small number of accurately relevant tags does more than a wall of loosely-related ones.

DO

✎ Worksheet — Turn Search Demand Into Social Content

Pull 5 themes from your Keyword Universe (Section 4), Content Clusters (Section 12), or 30 Content Opportunities (Section 13) — don't start from scratch.

SEARCH THEME	CUSTOMER QUESTION/INTENT	PLATFORM	CONTENT ANGLE	FORMAT	OPENING/HOOK	RELEVANT PRODUCT/COLLECTI

✨ **ASK AI**

Here are search themes from my Shopify keyword research: [paste 5–10 themes from your Keyword Universe or Content Clusters]. Suggest a short-form video content angle (TikTok/Reels style) for each — a specific hook and topic, not a script — that would genuinely interest someone researching this before buying [your product type].

Use the output as a starting angle, not a finished script — and remember AI has no idea what's currently trending on either platform; verify a format or trend actually still works before building content around it.

What to actually measure

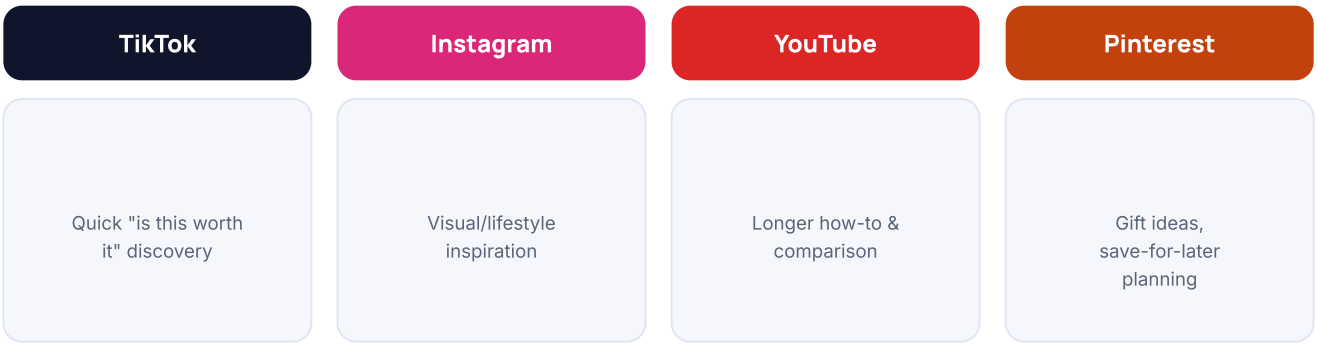
Don’t build a full social analytics practice around this — a light check is enough:

- Search-driven views, where a platform exposes that data specifically
- Saves and shares (often a stronger signal of genuine usefulness than a raw view count)
- Watch time / completion rate, where visible
- Profile visits and clicks through to your site

Views alone don’t equal business value — a video with modest views but real saves, comments asking where to buy, and site clicks is doing more for your store than a much bigger view count that goes nowhere.

> **CHECK YOUR WORK**

Look at your worksheet’s “Next action” column. If most rows say something like “just posted it” with no clear next action defined, that’s fine for a first attempt — but as you build more of these, you should start noticing patterns in what actually drives saves, comments, or site clicks, and lean into that.



PART 8

AI SEARCH

08

✦ YOUR SYSTEM SO FAR

- Part 0 · Your Starting Point
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YOU ARE HERE

Part 8 — AI Search

AI Self-Test | AI Readiness

- Part 9 · Measure What Is Working
- Part 10 · The 90-Day Shopify SEO Plan

SECTION 20

What Happens When Someone Asks ChatGPT What to Buy?

LEARN

People increasingly ask AI assistants questions like *"what's a good non-toxic candle?"*, *"best soy candles for a bedroom,"* or *"what candle brands avoid paraffin?"* — questions that used to go straight to Google.

Here's an honest starting point: **there is no single, universal "AI ranking algorithm"** the way there's roughly one Google to optimize for. Different AI assistants are built differently, and each may draw on some combination of its own trained knowledge, live web retrieval, specific third-party sources it favors, and — where available — direct product data feeds. Exactly how any one system decides what to mention shifts by product, by mode (a quick chat answer vs. a "search" or "research" mode), and over time as these systems keep changing. Be wary of anyone — including this workbook, if it ever claims otherwise — presenting one fixed formula for "how AI search works."

A quick note on terminology. You may see terms like GEO (generative engine optimization), AEO (answer engine optimization), LLMO, or "AI SEO" — sometimes used interchangeably, sometimes with someone insisting on a precise distinction between them. As of 2026, there's genuinely no standardized, agreed-upon definition across the industry — practitioners use these terms differently from each other. You do not need to pick a side in that terminology debate or become an "AEO expert." The underlying question that actually matters is much simpler:

> NOTE
>
> **Is my business and product information clear, accurate, consistent, and genuinely discoverable across the web?**

That question is useful regardless of which acronym eventually wins.

What NOT to do: don't chase an invented formula

You may encounter confident-sounding advice shaped like: *"1. Add schema. 2. Get mentioned on Reddit. 3. Add FAQs. 4. Rank in ChatGPT."* Treat any claim shaped like that with real skepticism — it overstates both how predictable these systems are and how much control any single business has over them. Here's a more honest breakdown:

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES	WHAT THIS MEANS
Established good practice	A crawlable, indexable website; clear, accurate product and business information; genuinely useful content; structured data where appropriate; a real, findable presence beyond your own site	Worth doing regardless of AI search — this is also just good SEO and good business

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES	WHAT THIS MEANS
Plausible / emerging AI-discovery practice	Making product relationships and comparisons especially clear; directly answering common use-case and comparison questions; earning relevant third-party mentions; periodically checking how AI assistants answer questions about your category	Reasonable to invest some effort in, but based on current observation and pattern-matching, not proven mechanics
Not guaranteed by anything you do	Being cited by a specific AI assistant; being included in a specific answer; being recommended over a competitor; consistent behavior across different models or over time	Don't let anyone — including this workbook — sell you certainty here

AI search isn't just "Google with a chat box"

Traditional search hands you a list of links and lets you decide. An AI assistant may instead synthesize an answer, directly compare a few options, cite only a handful of sources it chose, or ask a follow-up question before answering. That changes what kind of information is actually useful to have out in the world: clear, structured, easily-summarized information about what you sell and who it's for is more valuable in this environment than it ever was for traditional search alone — but it still doesn't buy you a guaranteed mention.

Product information clarity — you've already started this work

The clearest lever you actually control is the same one you built in Section 8: does your product page clearly answer *what is this, who is it for, what makes it different, and what are the specifications* — in plain, unambiguous language? That's not new work for this section; it's the same good product information helping three audiences at once (real shoppers, traditional search, and AI systems trying to summarize your page), not three separate optimization projects.

Third-party presence — carefully

AI assistants often lean on sources beyond a brand's own website — reviews, editorial coverage, retailer listings, genuine community discussion, relevant creator mentions. A real, legitimate presence beyond your own domain can matter here, the same way it's always mattered for reputation and trust generally.

> **ETHICAL WARNING**
>
> Do not manufacture this. Don't post fake reviews, seed deceptive "organic" Reddit threads, pay for disguised mentions, or spam forums with your brand name. Beyond being dishonest, manufactured presence is often detectable, can damage real trust with actual customers, and isn't a reliable strategy even on its own cynical terms — it's not how legitimate third-party credibility is built. Earn mentions by being a business worth mentioning.



DO

✎ Worksheet — Your AI Search Self-Test

Manually run a small set of real prompts through an AI assistant you have access to (ChatGPT, Google's AI-powered search experiences, Perplexity, Microsoft Copilot — whichever you can access). Try a mix of prompt types:

- **Category:** "What are good [your product category] brands?"
- **Use case:** "Best [your product] for [specific use case]"
- **Attribute:** "[Product type] brands without [thing you avoid/differentiate on]"
- **Brand:** "What is [your business name]?"

For each prompt, record:

PROMPT	WAS MY BRAND MENTIONED?	WAS THE INFO ACCURATE?	SOURCES CITED (IF SHOWN)	COMPETITORS MENTIONED	WHAT SEEMED TO INFLUENCE THE ANSWER	ANYTHING WRONG OR MISSING?

IMPORTANT

this is a snapshot, not a scientific ranking report. The same prompt can return a different answer based on the model, the session, your location, personalization, what that system happened to retrieve at that moment, and even small differences in how you phrased the question. **If your brand isn't mentioned once, that does not mean you have an "AI SEO score of zero"** — it means you have one data point, taken at one moment, from one system. Run this periodically (monthly or quarterly is plenty) and watch for a *pattern* over time, the same discipline you're already applying to Search Console in Part 6 — not a one-time verdict.

CHECK YOUR WORK

Look at your “Anything wrong or missing” column first. Inaccurate information about your own business appearing in an AI answer is worth noting and, where you can identify the likely source (an outdated listing, an old review, incorrect info on a directory), worth correcting at the source — that’s a concrete, useful action this exercise can surface, regardless of whether you were mentioned favorably or not at all.

SECTION 21

AI Search Readiness Checklist

LEARN

Rather than a numeric score implying precision this field doesn’t actually have, rate yourself honestly across five areas: **Strong / Needs Work / Not Yet or Unknown.**

DO

✎ Worksheet — AI Search Readiness Checklist

Business Clarity — could a machine reading your site easily determine:

- [ ] Your brand name, unambiguously
- [ ] What you sell, in plain terms
- [ ] Who it's for
- [ ] What category/categories you belong to
- [ ] Your location, if relevant to the business

Rating: ☐ Strong ☐ Needs Work ☐ Not Yet/Unknown

Product Clarity — for your key products, is it clear:

- [ ] What type of product it is
- [ ] Materials/ingredients where relevant
- [ ] Key features
- [ ] Typical use cases
- [ ] Specifications (size, quantity, etc.)
- [ ] What meaningfully differentiates it from similar products

Rating: ☐ Strong ☐ Needs Work ☐ Not Yet/Unknown

Site Clarity — from your Part 6 technical check:

- [ ] Important pages are indexable (Section 16–17)
- [ ] Site architecture is logical, not a flat pile of products (Section 6)
- [ ] Headings organize information clearly (Section 14)
- [ ] Internal links connect related information (Section 15)
- [ ] Basic structured data is present and accurate (Section 18 — not re-explained here, just confirmed)

Rating: ☐ Strong ☐ Needs Work ☐ Not Yet/Unknown

Trust / Corroboration

- [ ] Genuine customer reviews exist and are visible
- [ ] Your business is findable somewhere beyond your own website (a directory, press mention, marketplace listing, social presence)
- [ ] Information about your business is consistent across the places it appears (same name, same category, no contradictions)

Rating: ☐ Strong ☐ Needs Work ☐ Not Yet/Unknown

Question Coverage

- [ ] Your site actually answers the real questions people ask before buying (pull from your Section 13 customer-question research)
- [ ] FAQs exist where they genuinely remove doubt — not chasing a search-result feature (see note below)

Rating: ☐ Strong ☐ Needs Work ☐ Not Yet/Unknown

NOTE

A reminder carried from Sections 8 and 17: structured data and FAQs are genuinely useful for the "Site Clarity" and "Question Coverage" categories above — they make information explicit and machine-readable. Neither one is a confirmed lever for earning an AI citation, and FAQ content specifically has no connection to Google's (now-discontinued) FAQ rich result. Include them because they make your site clearer to everyone reading it, human or machine — not because either one is a guaranteed unlock.

✨ ASK AI

This is a genuinely useful, different use of AI than anything else in this workbook: using it to test whether your own writing is actually clear, not to predict whether you'll be cited anywhere.

> *Here is the text from my product page: [paste your actual product page copy]. Based only on this text, tell me: what product do you think this is? Who do you think it's for? What materials or specifications can you identify? What important information seems to be missing that a buyer would want to know? Are any claims ambiguous or unclear?*

If the AI's answers are vague, wrong, or missing something obvious, that's a real, useful signal that your page isn't as clear as you think it is — regardless of what any AI assistant does or doesn't cite later.

CHECK YOUR WORK

Count your "Not Yet/Unknown" ratings. Two or more in the same category (especially Business Clarity or Product Clarity) is worth addressing before worrying about anything else in this Part — those are foundational, not advanced. A single "Needs Work" in Trust/Corroboration is completely normal for a small or newer store and builds naturally over time as you get real reviews and a genuine web presence.

PART 9

09

MEASURE WHAT IS WORKING

✦ YOUR SYSTEM SO FAR

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- Part 8 · AI Search

YOU ARE HERE

Part 9 — Measure What Is Working

Search Scorecard

Part 10 · The 90-Day Shopify SEO Plan

```
Keyword Universe → Search Intent → Site Architecture → Collections → Products
    → Content Clusters → 30 Content Opportunities → On-Page SEO → Internal Links
    → Technical Health Check → Social Content → AI Readiness
```

You've built the system. This Part is about knowing whether it's actually working — and turning that answer into a decision, not just a number to stare at.

SECTION 22

Your Organic Search Scorecard

LEARN

You already know how to read Google Search Console (Section 17) — this section isn't that again. This is about turning numbers you already know how to find into a monthly habit that tells you what to do next. **A metric is only useful if it changes what you do.** A number you check and then do nothing differently about isn't measurement — it's a ritual.

Three different kinds of metric, from three different questions

CATEGORY	ANSWERS	METRICS
Visibility	Is Google showing me at all?	Impressions, queries, position trends
Traffic	Are people coming?	Clicks, organic sessions
Business outcome	Is it actually making money?	Conversions, revenue, conversion rate, revenue per organic visitor

Notice the order: visibility doesn't guarantee traffic, and traffic doesn't guarantee revenue. **Rankings are not the goal — they're one early input toward the goal.** A store fixated on visibility metrics alone can "win" at SEO and still not grow, if the traffic doesn't convert.

Where each number actually comes from

Don't mix these as if one system calculated all of them — they use different measurement methods and don't always agree with each other, and that's normal, not a bug:

SYSTEM	PROVIDES
Google Search Console (Section 17)	Impressions, clicks, queries, average position
Shopify Analytics (or your analytics platform)	Organic sessions, conversions, revenue, conversion rate

What changed, and what should I do? — reading patterns, not panicking at numbers

PATTERN	WORTH ASKING	NOT A UNIVERSAL CAUSE
Impressions up, clicks flat	Are rankings improving but still low on the page? Are titles/snippets (Section 14) actually inviting a click? Are the queries genuinely relevant to what you sell?	Don’t assume “Google broke something”
Clicks up, sales flat	Is this traffic commercially relevant, or mostly informational? Are visitors landing on an article with no clear next step? Is the product page itself converting once they arrive?	Don’t assume the keywords were “wrong”
Traffic flat, revenue up	Often genuinely good news — you’re converting existing visitors better, or attracting higher-value ones. Not every growth story shows up as a traffic chart	—
One page driving most of your growth	What’s it doing right (Section 14’s framework) that your other pages aren’t yet?	Don’t assume it’s luck — dig into what’s actually different
Impressions declining	Check, in order: seasonality (Section 3’s Trends check), a recent page change, an indexing issue (Section 16–17), or a genuine shift in competition or demand	Don’t assume a penalty — that’s rarely the real cause

Establishing a baseline

If this is your first month, you don’t have a trend yet — you have a starting point. Write “this is where we started” and move on; a small first-month number is not a failure, it’s the only number that could exist on day one.

GOOD TO KNOW

AVOID DAILY SEO OBSESSION. Checking rankings every morning, reacting to a one-day dip, or rewriting a page because its position moved three spots is a fast path to anxiety without useful signal — daily search data is noisy by nature (Section 17). Review this scorecard monthly. If something feels genuinely urgent, it usually shows up as a sustained multi-week pattern, not a single day’s number.

DO

✎ Worksheet — Monthly Organic Search Scorecard

METRIC	PREVIOUS MONTH	CURRENT MONTH	CHANGE	WHAT I NOTICE	WHAT I'LL INVESTIGATE / DO
Indexed pages (Sec. 17)					
Impressions (GSC)					
Clicks (GSC)					
Organic sessions (Shopify Analytics)					
Top query (GSC)					
Top page (GSC)					
Organic conversion rate					
Organic revenue					
This month's wins:					
This month's open questions:					
Next month's priorities:					

Reconnecting SEO to your business

Back in Section 2, you filled out your Customer Acquisition Economics — except for one field you couldn't honestly fill in yet: *the value of an organic conversion.* You have the data now (or will, once your store has a few weeks of history). Here's how to calculate it:

- **Organic conversion rate** = organic orders ÷ organic sessions
- **Organic revenue** = total revenue from orders attributed to organic sessions (from your analytics platform)
- **Revenue per organic visitor** = organic revenue ÷ organic sessions

A CAVEAT

attribution isn't perfect — a customer might discover you organically, leave, and come back later through a bookmark or a direct search for your brand name, and get counted differently depending on your analytics setup. Treat these numbers as a genuinely useful *approximation*, not an audited financial figure. Don't manufacture false precision by carrying them out to decimal places that imply more certainty than the underlying data supports.

✨ **ASK AI**

A genuinely useful pattern-spotting use, with a specific guardrail built into the prompt itself:

> *Here's my monthly organic search scorecard: [paste your actual filled-in scorecard or a Search Console/Shopify Analytics export]. Separate your response into three clearly labeled sections: OBSERVED (only what the data literally shows), POSSIBLE EXPLANATIONS (plausible reasons, clearly framed as hypotheses, not facts), and WHAT TO CHECK (specific things I could look at to test those hypotheses). Do not state a cause as certain — for example, don't tell me traffic dropped 'because of' a Google penalty or algorithm change unless the data specifically shows that; frame it as one possibility to investigate, not a conclusion.*

This structure matters: a simple spreadsheet cannot tell an AI system *why* a number moved — it can only help you organize what's worth investigating.

CHECK YOUR WORK

Look at your "What I'll investigate / do" column. If most rows are blank or say "not sure," that's a sign you're recording numbers without yet turning them into decisions — go back through the pattern table above and force at least one real question per significant change.

SECTION 23

How Long Does SEO Take?

LEARN

Kept short on purpose — you don't need another chapter here, just honest expectations before you start executing your 90-day plan.

Timing depends on factors you've already met throughout this workbook: your site's history and existing authority, how competitive your space is, real demand for what you sell, your technical health (Part 6), content quality, how consistently you execute, and seasonality. **No honest answer gives you a specific number of days, weeks, or months** — anyone promising "page one in 30 days" is not being straight with you.

Leading signals show up before lagging ones:

SHOWS UP EARLIER	SHOWS UP LATER
Pages getting discovered and indexed	Sustained, meaningful traffic
Impressions starting to appear	Content assisting product discovery
More queries showing up in Search Console	Conversions
Small movement in visibility for long-tail terms	Revenue you can attribute with confidence

This isn't a guaranteed sequence — some stores see it play out cleanly, others don't — but it's a useful lens: if you're seeing zero leading signals after a couple of months, that's worth investigating (Part 6). If leading signals exist but haven't become traffic yet, that's often just time, not failure.

Expect uneven, not linear, progress. SEO rarely looks like "10 visits, then 20, then 30" in a smooth line. A page can sit quietly for weeks and then start appearing for more searches, often for reasons that aren't fully visible from the outside (a competitor's page changed, a seasonal shift happened, Google reassessed the page). Don't read a quiet month as proof nothing is working — and don't read one great week as proof you've cracked it. Look for the trend, not any single data point.

PART 10

10

THE 90-DAY SHOPIFY SEO PLAN

✦ YOUR SYSTEM SO FAR

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YOU ARE HERE

Part 10 — The 90-Day Shopify SEO Plan

90-Day Plan | Final SEO Plan

You've spent this whole workbook answering "what could I do?" This Part answers the harder question: **what do I actually do, in what order, starting Monday?**

SECTION 24

Your 90-Day Plan

LEARN — start here, not at Week 1

Before you follow this plan on autopilot, figure out which situation actually describes your store — the right starting emphasis genuinely differs:

YOUR SITUATION	START HERE
You failed one or more checks in Part 0	Fix those first (password protection, GSC, indexing) — everything else waits behind this
Existing store with many products/collections already, never done SEO deliberately	Audit before you build — apply Section 6's five-question framework to what already exists before creating anything new; consolidating overlapping collections often matters more than adding pages
Brand new store, few products/pages yet	Build cleanly from the start using this plan in order — you have less to untangle
Store passed Part 0, technically healthy	Skip straight into architecture and page work — no need to linger on Week 1's technical items

Effort key used throughout: 🟢 Quick (under an hour) · 🟡 Moderate (a few hours) · 🔴 Substantial (half a day or more, or spread across the week)

Phase 1: Days 1–30 — Foundation

Goal: get the plumbing working and make your first real priority decisions. By the end of this phase, Google can find you, you know what you're targeting, and you've decided your architecture.

WEEK	FOCUS	MUST DO	SHOULD DO	TOOL/SECTION
1	Measurement + discoverability	🟢 Fix any Part 0 red flags · 🟢 Set up Search Console · 🟢 Submit sitemap	🟡 Run the Section 18 technical check	Part 0, Sec. 17, Sec. 18
2	Keyword & priority decisions	🟡 Build your Keyword Universe · 🟡 Classify by Search Intent	🟢 Run the Section 3 competitor spot-check	Sec. 4, Sec. 5
3	Architecture decisions	🔴 Decide your site architecture · 🟡 Build your Collection Map (existing stores: audit/consolidate first)	🟢 Sketch supporting content connections	Sec. 6, Sec. 7

WEEK	FOCUS	MUST DO	SHOULD DO	TOOL/SECTION
4	First real optimization	●●● Fully optimize one product · ●●○ Fully optimize your top collection	●●○ Start your Internal Linking Plan · ●○○ Connect the Google & YouTube channel and check free listings status	Sec. 8 , Sec. 9 , Sec. 10 , Sec. 15

By day 30, you should have: an indexable, measured store; a real keyword universe and intent map; a decided architecture; and at least one fully optimized product and collection. That's the foundation everything else builds on.

Phase 2: Days 31–60 — Optimization

Goal: shift from foundation into execution. By the end of this phase, your priority pages are optimized, connected, and your first content is live.

WEEK	FOCUS	MUST DO	SHOULD DO	TOOL/SECTION
5–6	Optimize the rest	●●● Work through the repeatable catalog checklist on remaining priority products/collections	●●○ Finish your Internal Linking Plan	Sec. 8 's checklist, Sec. 10 , Sec. 15
7	First supporting content	●●○ Build your first content cluster · ●●● Publish your first 2–3 articles from your 30 Opportunities list	●○○ Link each new article into its cluster's commercial page	Sec. 12 , Sec. 13
8	Cleanup + first reuse	●●○ Resolve any remaining Yellow items from your Technical Check	●○○ Turn one already-published piece into content for your highest-likelihood social channel (from your "Where Can Customers Discover Me?" worksheet)	Sec. 18 , Sec. 19

By day 60, you should have: every priority page optimized and linked, a working content cluster with real published articles, and your first piece of social content reusing work you'd already done — not built from scratch.

Phase 3: Days 61–90 — Growth

Goal: expand deliberately, and start operating on a real measurement cycle instead of a launch checklist.

WEEK	FOCUS	MUST DO	SHOULD DO	TOOL/SECTION
9–10	Content expansion	●●● Publish more from your 30 Opportunities list, prioritized (Sec. 13) · ●●○ Only build a new commercial page if it survives the Section 6 five-question test — don't create pages just to have more pages	—	Sec. 6 , Sec. 12 , Sec. 13

WEEK	FOCUS	MUST DO	SHOULD DO	TOOL/SECTION
11	AI & third-party readiness	●●● Work through your AI Search Readiness Checklist · ●●● Identify one or two legitimate places your brand could genuinely earn a mention (never manufactured — Section 20's ethical warning)	●●● Run your AI Search Self-Test	Sec. 20, Sec. 21
12	Review & reset	●●● Fill out your Month 3 Scorecard and compare against your Month 1 baseline · ●●● Set your next-cycle priorities	—	Sec. 22

By day 90, you should have: an expanding, connected content system; a real AI-readiness self-assessment; and — critically — three months of scorecard data telling you what to prioritize next.

KEEP IN MIND

THE 90-DAY PLAN IS THE START OF A CYCLE, NOT A FINISH LINE. SEO doesn't complete on day 90 — your store now has an operating rhythm: monthly scorecard reviews (Section 22), a growing content pipeline (Sections 12–13), and a technical check-in (Section 18) whenever something changes. Day 91 isn't "done" — it's "repeat the cycle, informed by three months of real data instead of a guess."



SECTION 25

Printable 90-Day Checklist

DO

✎ CHECKLIST — keep this next to your desk

✓	TASK	TARGET	SECTION	DONE
☐	Fix any Part 0 red flags	Day 1	Part 0	____
☐	Set up Search Console + submit sitemap	Week 1	Sec. 17	____
☐	Run technical check	Week 1	Sec. 18	____
☐	Build Keyword Universe	Week 2	Sec. 4	____
☐	Classify Search Intent	Week 2	Sec. 5	____
☐	Decide site architecture	Week 3	Sec. 6	____
☐	Build Collection Map	Week 3	Sec. 7	____
☐	Optimize one product fully	Week 4	Sec. 8	____
☐	Optimize top collection fully	Week 4	Sec. 10	____
☐	Connect Google & YouTube channel, check free listings	Week 4	Sec. 9	____
☐	Optimize remaining priority products/collections	Weeks 5–6	Sec. 8 & 10	____
☐	Finish Internal Linking Plan	Weeks 5–6	Sec. 15	____
☐	Build first content cluster	Week 7	Sec. 12	____
☐	Publish first 2–3 articles	Week 7	Sec. 13	____
☐	Resolve remaining Yellow technical items	Week 8	Sec. 18	____
☐	Reuse content for top social channel	Week 8	Sec. 19	____
☐	Publish more from content opportunities list	Weeks 9–10	Sec. 13	____
☐	Complete AI Search Readiness Checklist	Week 11	Sec. 21	____
☐	Run AI Search Self-Test	Week 11	Sec. 20	____
☐	Fill Month 3 Scorecard, compare to baseline	Week 12	Sec. 22	____
☐	Set next-cycle priorities	Week 12	Sec. 22	____

SECTION 26

Final Workbook — Build Your Shopify SEO Plan

This is the condensed version of everything you built. It should take you 20–30 minutes to fill out — you're not doing new thinking here, just pulling your best answers forward from the worksheets where you already did the real work.

✎ My Shopify SEO Plan

My #1 organic growth goal:

My top product categories:

My highest-priority collections:

My primary keywords:

My secondary keyword opportunities:

My first content cluster:

My first 10 articles: 1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____ 4. _____ 5. _____ 6. _____ 7. _____ 8. _____ 9. _____ 10. _____ *(from Sec. 13)*

My technical priorities:

My internal linking priorities:

My social search strategy:

My AI search priorities:

My measurement baseline (Month 1):

My 30-day goal:

My 60-day goal:

My 90-day goal:

SECTION 27

The Small Business SEO Toolkit

LEARN

This is not a list of 30 subscriptions. It's the smallest stack that actually gets the job done — organized by what you're trying to accomplish, not by brand name.

If you only use a handful of tools, use these:

TOOL	JOB IT DOES	COST
Google Search Console	Indexing, performance, the source of truth for "is Google finding me"	Free
Google Trends	Seasonality and demand direction	Free
Google Keyword Planner	Rough search-volume ranges (Section 3's no-spend workaround)	Free
Ahrefs Webmaster Tools	Backlink data and a basic technical crawl of your own verified site	Free
PageSpeed Insights	Speed and Core Web Vitals	Free
Rich Results Test	Structured data check	Free
Google Merchant Center	Free product listings on Google's Shopping tab and other product surfaces (Section 9)	Free
Your own Shopify admin	On-site search terms, sales/analytics data	Free (already included)

Every single one of these is free. **That's not a compromise version of "real" SEO — for a store your size, this genuinely is a legitimate, complete DIY toolkit.** You do not need a $500/month software stack to run the process this workbook teaches.

The full reference — organized by job:

CATEGORY	TOOL	FREE/FREEMIUM/PAID	USE IT FOR	DO YOU NEED IT?
Keyword research	Google Keyword Planner	Free (Ads account, no spend required)	Volume ranges, real Google data	**Start here**
Keyword research	Keywords Everywhere	Freemium — paid credits for volume/difficulty data in-browser	Faster keyword lookups without leaving Google	Use when needed, not day one

CATEGORY	TOOL	FREE/FREEMIUM/PAID	USE IT FOR	DO YOU NEED IT?
Keyword research	Ubersuggest	Freemium — a few free lookups/day, paid plans for more	An alternative keyword/content-idea source	Optional
Search trends	Google Trends	Free	Seasonality, rising/falling interest	**Start here**
Search performance/indexing	Google Search Console	Free	Everything in Part 6	**Start here**
Search performance/indexing	Bing Webmaster Tools	Free	A second search engine's view; can import GSC data	Worth the 10-minute setup
Product/Shopping visibility	Google Merchant Center	Free	Free product listings across Google's Shopping tab, Images, Lens, and more (Section 9)	**Start here**
Technical checks	PageSpeed Insights	Free	Speed, Core Web Vitals	**Start here**
Technical checks	Chrome Lighthouse (DevTools)	Free, built into your browser	Same engine as PageSpeed Insights, on demand	Use when needed
Technical checks	Screaming Frog	Free up to 500 URLs; paid license for larger crawls	A deeper technical crawl than this workbook's manual checks	Optional/advanced — most small stores won't hit the 500-URL ceiling
Structured data	Rich Results Test	Free	Confirm what Google reads from your product schema	**Start here**
Structured data	Schema Markup Validator	Free	Broader schema.org validation	Use when needed
Content research	AnswerThePublic	Freemium — a few free searches/day, paid for more	Question-phrased search ideas for Section 13	Optional
Content research	Reddit, forums, reviews (Section 13's method)	Free	Real customer language and questions	**Start here** — this is a method, not a subscription
Competitor research	Incognito-window search check (Section 3's method)	Free	Who's really competing for a term	**Start here** — this is a method, not a subscription

CATEGORY	TOOL	FREE/FREEMIUM/PAID	USE IT FOR	DO YOU NEED IT?
Competitor research	Ahrefs Webmaster Tools	Free (own verified site only — doesn't show competitor data on the free tier)	Your own backlink profile	Already in your minimum stack
Analytics/revenue	Shopify Analytics	Free (built into every plan)	Organic sessions, conversions, revenue (Section 22)	**Start here**
Social search research	Each platform's native search bar	Free	See what autocompletes/ranks for your topics directly	**Start here** — this is a method, not a subscription
AI search research	Manual self-test (Section 20)	Free	Your own AI Search Self-Test worksheet	**Start here** — sufficient for a small store

Optional/advanced, further down the list — Semrush (a genuinely deep platform, but its free tier is capped at 10 lookups a day, and its real value only shows up on a paid plan aimed more at agencies than a single small store) and Moz (a long, useful free trial, but entry pricing is built for a business with a dedicated marketing budget). Neither is wrong to use later — they're just not where a small Shopify store should start. There are also emerging paid tools specifically for tracking brand mentions inside AI assistant answers — genuinely interesting, but built for brands managing this at a scale a small store doesn't need yet; the manual AI Search Self-Test from Section 20 covers what you actually need right now.

DON'T DO THIS

Don't subscribe to three overlapping tools that all claim to do "keyword research." Pick one from each row of your minimum stack, actually use it, and only add a paid tool when you can name the *specific* thing your free tools aren't giving you — not because a sales page made it sound essential.

CHECK YOUR WORK

Count how many tools from your minimum stack you've actually opened and used, not just bookmarked. If it's fewer than 5, that's the actual next step — not researching a sixth tool.

SECTION 28

Don’t Waste Your Money

LEARN

You don’t need to buy everything a Shopify app store notification or a cold sales email tells you that you need. Here’s what a new or small store usually doesn’t need *yet* — with an honest note on when that might change, because “always a waste” is rarely true and “not right for where you are today” usually is.

PROBABLY NOT YET	WHY	WHEN IT MIGHT MAKE SENSE LATER
Multiple overlapping SEO apps	Most solve the same 1–2 problems your free toolkit (Section 27) already covers	If you outgrow a specific free tool’s limits — but that’s a “one tool” decision, not a “buy the bundle” one
Enterprise SEO platforms (Semrush, Moz, Ahrefs paid tiers)	Built for agencies managing many sites, not one small store	Once you’re managing SEO across multiple sites or need competitor data at real scale
Expensive rank-tracking software, before you have meaningful visibility	Tracking daily position swings on a handful of queries with almost no traffic yet is data with nothing to act on	Once you have real query volume and want to watch specific priority terms over time
Hundreds of bulk AI-generated blog posts	More pages isn’t the goal — Section 11 already covered this. A large pile of disconnected, low-quality content is a maintenance burden, not an asset	Never, as a strategy — quality and connection to your commercial pages matters more than volume at any store size
Purchased/questionable backlinks	Real risk of a Google penalty, and it doesn’t build the kind of genuine third-party trust Section 20 talked about	There’s no version of this that becomes a good idea
Fake reviews or paid “organic” mentions	Same ethical warning from Section 20 — detectable, damages real trust, doesn’t work even cynically	Never
A random schema/structured-data app installed without knowing what problem it solves	You may end up with conflicting or inaccurate schema, which can cause more confusion than having none (Section 18)	Once you have a specific, named structured-data gap you’ve confirmed with the Rich Results Test

PROBABLY NOT YET	WHY	WHEN IT MIGHT MAKE SENSE LATER
Paying for a report with no plan to act on it	The value is in implementation, not the PDF	If you genuinely don't have the time to implement — in that case, pair the report with actual implementation help, not just more reports
Constant, unnecessary theme modifications for marginal SEO gains	Real risk of breaking something for a small, speculative benefit	When a specific, confirmed technical issue actually requires a code fix (Section 18's "Consider Technical Help" bucket)
Chasing a perfect 100 PageSpeed score	Section 18 already covered this — diminishing returns past "no glaring red flags"	Rarely, if ever, worth dedicated spend for a small store
A separate collection for every keyword variation	Section 6 already covered this — thin, overlapping collections split your strength instead of building it	Only if a variation turns out to represent genuinely distinct demand, per Section 6's five-question test
Constantly changing URLs to chase a "prettier" keyword	Section 14 already covered this — breaks links and ranking history for marginal gain	Rarely — a genuine architecture change (Section 6) is different from cosmetic URL tweaking
Every new "AI SEO hack" that shows up in your feed	Section 20 already covered why: no one has a proven formula for this yet	Worth staying aware of, not worth paying for, until something is more established than "an emerging idea someone is selling access to"

Before you pay for any SEO tool or service, ask:

> NOTE
>
> **THE BUY / WAIT / SKIP CHECK** 1. What specific problem am I trying to solve? 2. Can a tool I already have solve it? 3. Will I actually use this often — not just once? 4. Is the information it gives me actually actionable? 5. Does it save enough time to justify the cost? 6. Am I solving a real, current bottleneck — or a hypothetical future one? If you can't answer #1 specifically, you're not ready to buy anything yet — go find the actual bottleneck first.

SECTION 29

What's Next

You've built a real, working organic search strategy for your store. Look at what's actually behind you now: a keyword universe, a decided site architecture and collection map, an optimized product and collection page framework, content clusters and a real content pipeline, an internal linking plan, a completed technical health check, a working Search Console measurement system, a social-search plan, an AI-readiness assessment, and a 90-day roadmap connecting all of it.

That's not a reading exercise you finished. It's a system you built, specific to your store, that you can keep operating on your own from here.

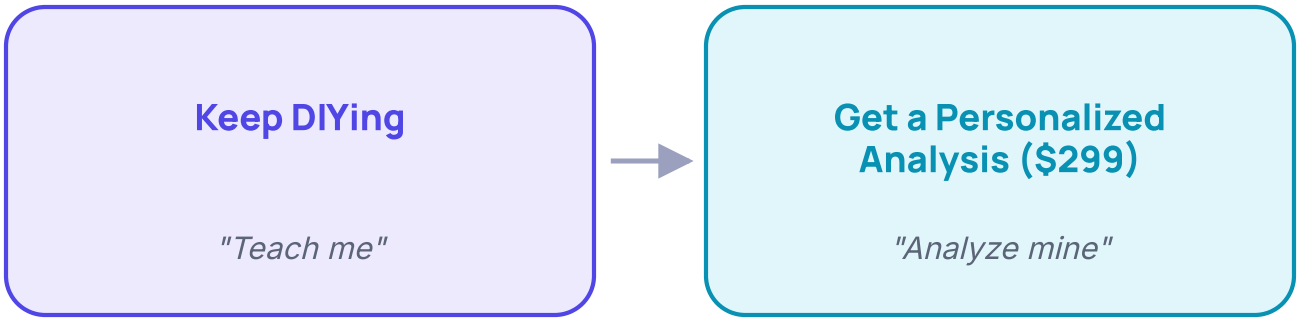
Where you go from here is genuinely up to you.

Path 1 — Keep DIYing

You can stop right here and simply run the system. The workbook is complete — everything you need to research, build, implement, and measure your own organic search strategy is already in your hands. You don't need to buy anything else for this to work. Revisit your 90-Day Plan (Section 24), keep your Scorecard (Section 22) running monthly, and keep working through your content pipeline (Section 13).

Path 2 — Get a Personalized Analysis ($299)

If you've finished this workbook thinking *"I understand the process now, but I want this depth of research actually performed for my specific business,"* that's what Scrolly's $299 SEO Site Audit does. Where this workbook taught you the method — manual keyword research, a five-question decision framework, a self-run technical spot-check — the Site Audit applies deeper research, professional-grade data, and automated analysis directly to your real store: bulk keyword and competitor research at a scale beyond what free tools show you, a full technical/indexation crawl of your actual site, and a prioritized roadmap built from your specific data rather than a general framework. It's the same kind of thinking this workbook taught you — done for your business, with tools and data beyond what a free DIY stack provides.



Whichever path you choose next, the work in this workbook is yours to keep — your keyword universe, your architecture, your content pipeline, your roadmap. That's the actual product.